ORACLE UNIFIED METHOD

WORKSHOP TECHNIQUES HANDBOOK

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Workshop Techniques Handbook, Release 1.1.0

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Authors:
Contributors: Tony Caselnova
Field Reviewers:
Project Editor:
Editors: Linda Lowitz

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Preface

The *Workshop Techniques Handbook* provides detailed descriptions of the techniques descriptions of the techniques available to consultants in delivering workshops delivering workshops during projects. The *Workshop Techniques Handbook* describes a set of organized and flexible techniques that guide consultants through the workshop.

The material in this guide includes a description of workshop techniques as well as guidelines on the prerequisites, approach, and roles and responsibilities. This handbook is provided to assist in expediting and standardizing all of the techniques delivered in a workshop.

This handbook is part of the Oracle Unified Method℠ (OUM)—Oracle's integrated approach to solution delivery.

Audience

The *Workshop Techniques Handbook* is written for consultants, team leaders and project leaders. Consultants and team leaders use this reference in detail to plan and facilitate workshop events. Team leaders and project leaders use this reference as an overview to understand the nature of tasks in order to better manage their execution. Enterprise and Solution Architects use this reference during Envision and pre-sales engagements to facilitate workshops for requirements gathering.

How the Manual is Organized

This handbook consists of an introduction chapter followed by a chapter on each of the workshop techniques available to consultants.

Chapter 1 - Introduction: The introduction presents an overview of workshops and typical approaches used in engagements. It also provides conventions used within the handbook.

Chapter 2 – Structuring Workshops: This chapter describes how to structure the event to gain the required result. This chapter covers the main issues around the four most important elements of a successful workshop:

- attendees
- structure
- facilitator
- workshop facilities

Chapter 3 – Techniques: This chapter describes in detail the techniques that can be used during a workshop. It does not claim to describe all possible techniques, but covers a wide enough range of techniques that allow any type of workshop to be constructed. Each technique has the following structure:

- title
- synopsis
- rationale (benefits of using this approach)
- approach (steps used to complete this activity
- output
- facilitator's role
- guidelines
- timings
- hints and tips
- credits (if applicable)

How to Use this Manual

The *Workshop Techniques Handbook* provides the approach for planning and delivering a workshop, including guidelines and advice. Use this manual as a reference guide for planning workshops and producing outputs that require technical and application expertise. Sample outputs included in this handbook, as well as the extensive information, assist in communicating the process and setting expectations with workshop participants. Where possible, examples are provided to aid the process.

All user of this reference should read the next section to better understand the conventions used in this manual.

Conventions Used in this Manual

Several notational conventions are used to make this handbook easy to read.

Suggestions

We provide you with helpful suggestions throughout the handbook to help you get the most out of the handbook. We highlight these suggestions with an illuminated light bulb. Here is an example of a suggestion:

Suggestion: Verify your backup and recovery plan with your hardware and software vendors.

Attention

We sometimes highlight especially important information or considerations to save you time or simplify the task at hand. We mark such information with an attention graphic, as follows:

Attention: Since project team training occurs simultaneously with this task, some recommendations (or decisions) from training may be implemented in the mapping environment. In this case, these training inputs become predecessors to this task.

For More Information

Throughout the handbook we alert you to additional information you may want to review. This may be a task section, appendix, or reference manual or web site. We highlight these references with an easy to notice graphic. Here is an example:

Reference: For more information about content for the Solution Design presentation, review the Critical Success Factors, page 3-7.

UPPERCASE TEXT

Uppercase text is used to call attention to command keywords, object names, filenames, and so on.

Italicized Text

Italicized text indicates the definition of a term or the title of a manual.

Bold Text

Bold text is designed to attract special attention to important information.

Your Comments are Welcome

Oracle Corporation values and appreciates your comments as a reader of this handbook. As we write, revise, and evaluate our documentation, your comments are the most valuable input we receive. If you would like to contact us regarding comments on this or other Oracle Method manuals, please use the following email address information:

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CHAPTER

1 Introduction

During any successful consultancy intervention, information, ideas, suggestions and information, ideas, suggestions and experience is transferred — these generally take transferred — these generally take the form of interviews or a workshop of some sort. This introductory chapter discusses the use of workshop during consulting engagements, and how to apply them in real projects.

Traditionally, the normal interview or an "extended meeting" approach has been used to gather information with customers. Increasingly, this has given way to using formal, structured workshops. This change in emphasis has occurred through an understanding of the following benefits of adopting a workshop-driven approach:

- It reduces the overall elapsed time of a project by obtaining information much more quickly than through individual interviews.
- It is easier to get a consensus when people are together, considering and working through the same issues.
- It forces a resolution of conflicting information.
- It gives everybody the opportunity to participate and provides an easy and pleasurable climate and environment.
- It makes sure that all information and conclusions are shared by the entire group.

What is a Workshop?

A workshop is an interactive event that has been convened to achieve certain objectives. The attendees of the workshop will be guided (facilitated) through a series of structured activities that will result in the required output. Workshops make full use of group dynamics, and the synergy generated from group interactions. The following approach typifies a workshop and shows the difference between a workshop and a meeting or an interview:

- It has a targeted objective.
- It has been carefully planned and structured.
- The workshop audience has been carefully selected.
- The audience is guided through a series of activities (group activities and tasks).
- It is facilitated by an independent consultant.
- It takes into account group dynamics.
- It enables the group to build upon individual contributions.
- It forces out "hidden agendas."
- The group works together to fulfill the objectives.
- The group gains consensus.
- The results of the workshop are published.

In an attempt to illustrate a typical workshop, the following example shows the kind of activities that could take place in an initial workshop that is attempting to define and agree on the business needs of a new system:

- The **objective** is to define the objectives of a new system being developed
- It is **facilitated** by **independent** consultants.
- The attendees are **empowered** senior business managers (the right people).
- The people work as a group and make use of **group dynamics**.
- The workshop is carefully **structured** as follows:

  ⇒ Brainstorm what their business needs.

  ⇒ Prioritize ideas based on their impact on the business.

  ⇒ Document potential objectives for the new system.

  ⇒ Present, discuss and agree on the final objectives.

  ⇒ Determine critical success factors (and their metrics) for the objectives to be met.

  ⇒ Create action plan.

- Gain group consensus.
- Publish results.

In summary, a workshop is about getting:

- the right people,
- at the right place,
- at the right time,
- with the right facilitator and workshop structure,
- to deliver the required results.

When are Workshops Used?

Apply workshops to any type of consulting engagement. Tailor a workshop specifically to gain required inputs or specific outputs within a project to facilitate the completion of an OUM Task.

Tailored Workshop

Apply workshops whenever the following events occur within a project, and input will be required from various people, such as:

- What are the Business Objectives of the Enterprise?
- What are the objectives of this project?
- What are the business requirements for a specific functional area?
- How does this business process work?
- Do we need to review our IT Strategy?
- How should the screen layouts look?
- What does the overall project look like?
- How can we get agreement on this specification?

Tailor workshops to suit any event. With careful planning and structuring, a good facilitator should be able to lead the participants of a workshop to a successful conclusion. Typically, workshops last between one to two days. However, workshops can last a few hours to a series of workshops that could last months, depending on the objective of the workshop.

Workshops in OUM

This guide can be applied to tasks in an Envision engagement or an Implementation engagement. These scoping study workshops are usually targeted to our customer's senior business managers, and a standard approach is suggested, although some tailoring may be required. They provide a proven structure that has worked well with other customers.

Structured workshop approaches can be applied to many OUM tasks. Refer to the Technical Guidelines page of OUM to access the Technique Guidelines Cross Reference.

Are Workshops Always Applicable?

Although workshops are of enormous value in consulting engagements, they are not universally acceptable. A customer may not be willing to support a workshop-driven approach for a number of reasons:

- It may be culturally unacceptable.
- It may be difficult to arrange.
- It may cause conflict.
- It may be costly.
- They have had bad workshop experiences in the past.

This section describes some of the potential barriers to a workshop approach being acceptable to a customer.

Culture

In some countries and companies, the workshop approach is not culturally acceptable. If this is the case, workshops should not be used. Invariably, in a workshop, the following occurs:

- some conflict of disagreement
- ideas
- decisions
- commitments

Any culture that shies away from these eventualities in an open forum will not benefit from a workshop approach. For example:

- A "hire and fire" culture will subdue any decisions being made — "I won't make a decision; if I get it wrong, I lose my job."
- Some cultures avoid open displays of disagreement and conflict. Without these open exchanges, workshops can never identify real issues or problems.
- A culture that suppresses open discussion of new ideas will have problems in generating new ideas through a brainstorming session.
- Hierarchical cultures where no one will speak if the senior manager is present will not have successful workshops.

Logistics

Getting the right people in the right place at the right time is not an easy task, and may be found to be logistically impossible, for example:

- Finding mutually acceptable dates may have a long lead-time.
- Corporate policy may not allow for all of the senior management team to be out of the office at the same time.

- The participants might not be geographically located to meet in a physical location, this may require the use of collaborative environments and web conferencing.

The temptation is great to use inappropriate substitutes to enable a workshop to be scheduled, but care must be taken to make sure that this does not impact on the quality of the workshop output.

Conflict

The attendees of a workshop, drawn from different facets of the customer's business, will undoubtedly have different perceptions and views on how their organization currently works and what is required for the future. This invariably leads to conflict or disagreement during the workshop. The role of the facilitator is to make sure any arising conflicts and disagreements can be "smoothed over" and a consensus can be obtained. However, some customers may wish to avoid the risk of conflict occurring in any workshop environment.

Costs

The costs of running a workshop are high *to the customer*, but through the associated costs of dedicating people for the workshop period. A two-day workshop for 15 attendees (plus associated preparation time) will have a major impact on the normal day-to-day tasks that the attendees normally perform. The customer may need to balance this against using a more traditional approach, such as interviewing, and gaining consensus through reviewing and agreeing on the final report.

Who Delivers Workshops?

Consultants plan and deliver customer workshops with the necessary support from specialist consultants.

This handbook provides a source of information to the people who are constructing or delivering workshops. It assumes that the lead consultant has significant experience in running workshops, and is familiar with the majority of the techniques outlined in this handbook.

Warning: Embarking upon the leadership of a workshop is a serious responsibility. If you do not have the experience, find a more appropriate consultant to lead the session.

For consultants who do not have experience in these techniques, and would like to gain some experience in delivering them, they should consider attending a workshop skills course.

CHAPTER

2 Structuring Workshops

For a workshop to be completely successful, three main ingredients are essential: the ingredients are essential: the attendees, a structured approach for attaining the approach for attaining the workshop objectives, and an experienced facilitator through which the workshop is driven to its natural conclusion. This chapter considers these elements and provides guidance in constructing workshops that work — workshops that deliver the required objectives.

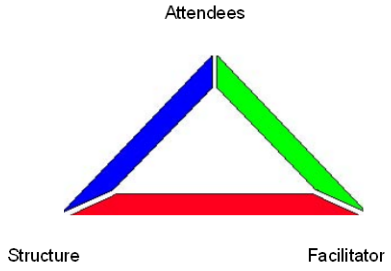

Figure 2-1 Workshop Construction

Workshop Attendees

Carefully design the structure and content of the target group. Attendance of inappropriate people will at best provide a poor quality result, and at worst, cause the workshop to fail. The basic attributes for the attendees for a workshop include:

- all empowered
- all committed
- representative of all parties involved
- representative of all necessary skills and information required
- all of a similar peer level

Select attendees (usually in conjunction with the customer project sponsor) against these criteria.

Empowerment

Design workshops to make decisions and agree on a way forward within a project. The attendees must be empowered to make these decisions. There is no point in running a workshop, and not being able to agree on anything without reference to a higher authority.

During the selection of the workshop attendees, it is essential the concept of empowerment is raised. If a particular individual must refer certain issues to the manager, then the manager would be a more ideal attendee than the individual concerned.

During the initial introductory presentations at the start of the workshop, it is useful if the project sponsor advises the participants that they are empowered to make the necessary decisions throughout the workshop.

Sometimes decisions have to be made at a very high level within a customer's organization, but the decision makers do not have the technical knowledge to make the decisions (for example, a new global technical architecture to support changes in the customer's business environment), and certainly the people with the technical expertise will not be allowed to make the decision either. One approach to resolve this impasse is to run a workshop with the technical people, and empower them to agree on three viable but different scenarios. These scenarios are then presented to a higher authority that makes the final selection.

In some customer cultures, empowering personnel is very unusual, and decisions are only made at a high level (and invariably, the decision makers are too busy to attend the workshops). In this case, run workshops in the usual way, but at the end of the session, a customer senior manager will attend, and the workshop attendees will present their findings and recommendations. The senior manager can then accept their findings and agree on the actions necessary to move the project forward.

Commitment

A commitment from the attendees to attain the objectives of the workshop is required. They will be the beneficiaries of the workshop results, and they have a vested interest in the workshop succeeding. Without the necessary commitment, a workshop can flounder, have a lack energy and excitement, and will usually conclude in a poor quality result.

Sometimes it is necessary to include attendees that are not fully committed to the workshop, for the following reasons:

- to accommodate the customer's internal politics
- to provide a better balance in the group
- to help "win over" a particular individual

This type of people **must** be in a minority, and the facilitator must be aware that there is a lack of commitment in certain individuals, so that he can plan accordingly. If these people are in the majority, the facilitator must consider whether the workshop event is viable.

Attendee Representation

The attendees must represent the right balance of business interests that the workshop is addressing. For example, if the event has been designed to develop an IT Vision of the future as part of an IT Strategy we would expect the attendees to represent all aspects of the business that the new IT Strategy would impact, as well as representation from IT.

In this example, if we had only selected IT personnel, there would be considerable risk that the workshop results would not fully support the needs of the business.

Skills/Experiences

In addition to the correct balance of business views, it is important that the group in total represents the necessary skills, information and experience necessary to achieve the workshop objectives.

Once you determine the workshop objectives, the skills and information source requirements can be understood. Select attendees to completely cover all the necessary skills and information sources.

If certain aspects of an information source will be missing (perhaps a key individual cannot attend), then the facilitator must consider the risks of running the workshop without access to key information.

Peer Group

Attendees of a workshop should be of a similar level to encourage equal weight and full consideration by others in any discussions, agreements and comments made during particular activities. Get a high degree of interactions for higher quality workshops.

Selecting attendees from several peer groups (from chief finance officer all the way down to the accounts payable clerk) results in a "mixed ability" group, which causes the following problems:

- differences in range of strategic thinking
- differences in the range of experience
- junior attendees' ideas may be ignored or suppressed
- junior attendees may not contribute for fear of saying the wrong things
- senior attendees may force through their ideas purely based on seniority

Avoid this type of group mix.

Other Considerations

Other considerations in selecting the attendees include the following:

- critical mass
- group dynamics

Critical Mass

For a workshop to work, you need a certain number of attendees to achieve critical mass. These will vary depending on the kinds of techniques you use. As an example, imagine running a Brainstorming session with only two people! You would certainly not reach critical mass. Imagine having to manage the output from a Brainstorming session of 60 people! A good rule of thumb is to use between 8 and 15 attendees in a workshop. This size provides the following benefits:

- provides critical mass — enough different views, ideas and perceptions about the objectives of the workshop
- small enough for the facilitator to manage easily
- provides enough ideas and views to "spark off" other attendees

However, do not include people just to "make up the numbers." Each attendee must be able to add value to the workshop.

Group Dynamics

Always consider how the overall group dynamics may work with the selected attendees. If the group works well, then there is a better chance of getting a higher quality result. Achieving a consensus is unlikely if many attendees are totally uncooperative.

This also applies to the creation of working groups or breakout groups. Consider the relevant personalities and the resultant group dynamics prior to selecting attendees for them.

Workshop Structure

The workshop structure includes the activities and techniques used to obtain the overall objectives of the workshop. Tailor the workshop structure to the customer's needs for the specific workshop, and take into account issues such as:

- What are the objectives of the workshop?
- What output is required?
- What time is available?
- Who are the attendees?
- What workshop techniques will be acceptable within their culture?

With this basic information we can begin to define the structure of the workshop, including:

- What presentation material will be required?
- What techniques will be used?
- How will we link activities together?
- How will we make sure that the workshop is effective?
- How will we use the overall group and working groups?
- How will we produce a detailed workshop plan?
- What encompasses the "bill of materials" for workshop activities?

Workshop Structure

Structure workshops into four main phases:

- initiation
- baseline
- solution
- actions

Use these phases to build the structure of activities to be used.

Initiation

Introduce the workshop through two short presentations. The first will be by the project sponsor, and then by the lead consultant.

The **project sponsor presentation** includes:

- welcome to the participants
- reasons why this workshop has been initiated
- the importance of this workshop to the customer

- what is expected of them (hard work, open minds, no interruptions, empowerment, etc.)
- introduction of the lead consultant

The **lead consultant presentation** includes:

- introductions of the facilitating team
- why the team is involved
- the objectives of the workshop
- why a workshop-driven approach is required
- format of the workshop (description of the four phases)
- agenda

The project sponsor should always introduce the workshop with the first presentation. This is vital as it drives home the fact that this is the **customer's workshop**, and that you are simply facilitating the session, driving it to a successful conclusion, and adding value as appropriate.

Positioning Presentation

The next step is generally through a positioning presentation. The facilitating team will be involved in this project due to its technology or applications. There may be a requirement for a short presentation to assure the audience is at the correct and common level of understanding, for example:

Workshop Objectives	Positioning Presentation
Initiating an IT Strategy	What is a strategy?
Introducing Enterprise Architecture	How EA can help streamline the Software investments in your organization?
Application Implementation Project	Why do we use a business process-oriented approach to application implementation?
Mapping Business Processes	What is a business process?

Table 2-1 Positioning Presentation Ice-Breaking Activity

Ice-Breaking Activity

Two ice-breaking activities are generally performed.

Each participant needs to introduce themselves to all the other attendees of the workshop. This enables everybody to begin to know each other. When working with a multi-national company, some attendees may never have met each other.

Attention: Strictly limiting these introductions is essential. If each of twelve participants spends ten minutes on their introduction, then a total of two hours will be used up!

The second ice-breaking activity may be either in the full group, or in individual working groups. This activity has two objectives:

- to get the group/working groups to begin to work as a team
- to gather some basic background information on the customer that is applicable to the workshop

Reference: A variant of "Understanding the Customer's Environment," discussed in Chapter 3, works well as an icebreaker for working groups.

Baseline

Complex problems and issues seldom have a single solution. It is therefore important to gather information about the problem or issue, and begin to gather information about the customer's future required state. This information will provide a baseline to draw upon when defining the scope for the next increment of the project.

Focus should be given to two main areas; an understanding of the current situation, and the problems and concerns they are trying to address during this project, and a creative, "out of the box" thinking session to gather their requirements for their hoped for future state.

Baseline activities allow the attendees to agree on and document the current situation within the customer's environment including a:

- shared perception of the problems
- "big picture" view of the environment

This could be the first time the customer has a total end-to-end perception of how the current environment works — due to the fact that people from different groups within a company are working together, sharing information, and agreeing a common view.

Techniques that can be applied in this phase include:

- value chain analysis
- SWOT analysis
- cause analysis
- vulnerability analysis
- wallcharting

Future State activities usually revolve around some form of Brainstorming activity to generate and document ideas about the state the customer wishes to be in the future.

Solution

The Solution phase concentrates on achieving the objectives of the workshop; allowing the attendees to explore and agree on the best way forward, based on the background information collected during earlier phases.

As our capability is diverse, then the Solution phase of a workshop will also be diverse in terms of the objectives. For example:

- creating a process diagram for their manufacturing operations
- determining the critical success factors and required prerequisites of implementing an application
- designing and agreeing on a set of screen layouts
- agreeing on the business drivers for a data warehouse
- identifying the business benefits of adopting NCA
- agreeing on a program plan, including inter-dependencies
- agreeing on the technical architecture — "Vision of the Future" for IS

Many different workshop techniques can be applied in this phase.

Actions

During a workshop the facilitator performs the following functions for the attendees:

- leads them through a series of activities
- helps them to consider all the issues and problems
- defines the solutions they require
- builds team spirit
- enables them to own the solution

If the facilitator just "declares victory" and walks away without a follow-up, then the workshop may not add value to the overall project.

It is of paramount importance that the workshop concludes in an action planning session. What are we going to do next? How can we take this forward? How can we address any obstacles?

The facilitator should lead this session, and the attendees should agree to progress the actions. The action planning activity will require the following information as a minimum:

- What is the action required?
- Who will own the action?
- When will the Terms of Reference be written?
- When will the action be started?
- When will the action be completed?
- How will any dependencies be documented?

- How will they report back to the steering group/project sponsor?

Facilitator

Typical definitions of the word **facilitate** include:

- to make easy
- to promote
- to help forward

This is exactly what a facilitator does during a workshop — he helps the customer *move forward* to make the required decisions, or *helps them* design a solution. He does this through his presence, his experience, and the planned activities designed to *make it easy* for the attendees to reach their goal.

The facilitator adds value to the customer's project by **helping them create their solution.**

For the customer to "own" his solution, the facilitator **must not be**:

- the person who writes down the information
- the person who makes the suggestions
- the person who advises them to adopt a particular scenario
- the person who picks up the actions at the end

Otherwise, the solution could be perceived as the facilitator's solution. Avoid this at all costs!

Personal Qualities

The main attributes required of a facilitator include:

- credibility
- confidence
- leadership qualities
- independence

A facilitator always has two roles within a workshop. The first role is the person who drives the workshop to its natural conclusion.

The facilitator must also take on the role of subject matter expert in order to add value to the workshop through making available the knowledge and experience of specific areas of interest to the workshop.

Running the Workshop

A facilitator, especially a lead consultant, has a significant influence on the success of a workshop by performing the following functions:

- planning the overall workshop structure
- managing the individual workshop activities
- handling problems (from dealing with difficult people, to problems deriving the information necessary to make decisions)
- "energizing" the group — keeping the momentum and pace going
- knowing when to "pull the plug" — Even though every effort has been made to make sure the workshop is a success — occasionally things do not work out as planned. What do you do when you find out that you cannot get the information necessary to result in the workshop objectives being met? Do you struggle on and still get nowhere, or do you stop the workshop?

Workshop Facilities

For a workshop to be effective, give consideration to the physical environment. This includes the venue for the workshop and the actual workshop environment.

The Workshop Venue

Carefully select the venue for any workshop. It must fulfill the following requirements:

- A neutral venue avoids the perception of "home advantage."
- The location must be conducive to spending a number of very intensive days throughout the duration of the workshop.
- The correct accommodation for the workshop sessions.
- The correct facilities available for the duration of the workshop.
- The workshop must be held at a venue that can stop interruptions during workshop sessions (such as phone calls).

Generally, external venues (conference centers or hotels), provide the most acceptable option. External venues provide the neutrality, a fresh and different environment in which to work, avoid interruptions (through a messaging service), and have experience of supporting these kind of events. These venues help take the burden of general housekeeping away from the facilitator or project manager.

One of the drawbacks of using external venues is cost. The customer will have to pay for all costs associated with the accommodations, and may have to incur overnight stays for attendees and the facilitator.

Some customers may want to use either their own premises, or the facilitating organization's. This should be avoided as much as possible because of the following potential obstacles:

- Can the correct accommodation be provided (a large meeting room and two break-out rooms next to each other)?
- Can calls be screened and interruptions managed?
- Can refreshments be ordered at 8.30 PM, if the workshop is working late?
- Can confidentiality of the workshop output be guaranteed during the duration of the workshop?
- Is the venue conducive to workshop activities, and considered neutral?
- Does the venue provide the opportunity for team building?

If the answer is "no" to any of these questions, then the facilitator and project sponsor should consider the possible impact this will have on the quality of the workshop, and balance it against the cost of an external venue.

The Workshop Environment

The selection of the venue depends largely on the ability to provide the necessary physical environment dictated by the workshop structure.

Workshop Accommodation

With the workshop structure (the techniques and activities) designed to make sure the workshop will drive out the objectives, it is now possible to determine the most appropriate accommodation for the workshop. Typical accommodation configurations are shown in the table below:

Type of Workshop	Typical Accommodation
workshop without working groups	large main room
workshop with working groups (A)	large main room plus break-out rooms
workshop with working groups (B)	large room, enabling work groups to work in each corner and not impacting on other work groups
wallcharting	very large room with the majority of wall space usable

Table 2-2 Workshop Accommodations

A large room is defined as being 7m x 10m (or 75 ft x 108 ft) — in conference room terms, this would typically seat 40 people for a presentation!

If breakout rooms are required, they should be larger than normally required for a meeting of 5-6 people, as additional space is required for workshop activities. A large wallcharting session (lasting many weeks) will require significant wall space to attach all intermediary results. An understanding of the estimated output will help select an appropriate room.

Seating

Workshops provide a dynamic environment in which to create solutions. The seating arrangements must be conducive to dynamic exchange.

Workshops require changes of pace and activity throughout the duration to help stimulate the attendees and maintain the momentum of their work.

As a workshop progresses the attendees will have different activities and a different physical environment for that task. This helps give the attendees “a change of scenery” and helps keep momentum going for extended periods.

Activity	Attendee Environment
initial presentations	seated - U-shaped table arrangement

Activity	Attendee Environment
ice-breaking activity	small groups - standing around a flip chart
value-chain analysis	whole group - standing, wallcharting
brainstorming	seated - U-shaped tables
setting objectives	seated in break-out rooms
identifying critical success factors	group presentations, other groups seated in main room
prioritization	simple voting while standing up
action planning	seated - U-shaped table

Table 2-3 Seating

The accommodation must suit the activities planned.

Workshop Room Sample Setup

The workshop will primarily consist of alternating discussions and presentations. The wall charts are numerous and will take up a great deal of wall space. It is suggested that you make sure the room will accommodate these charts.

A white Board and a flip chart will come in handy as you work through the process. Make sure there are no distractions and participants come prepared and focused. Turn off cell phones and instruct staff only to disturb the group in case of emergency. Here is a suggestion, or review the additional sample layouts.

This is type of setup would be used to discuss the ideas and the solutions that may be presented.

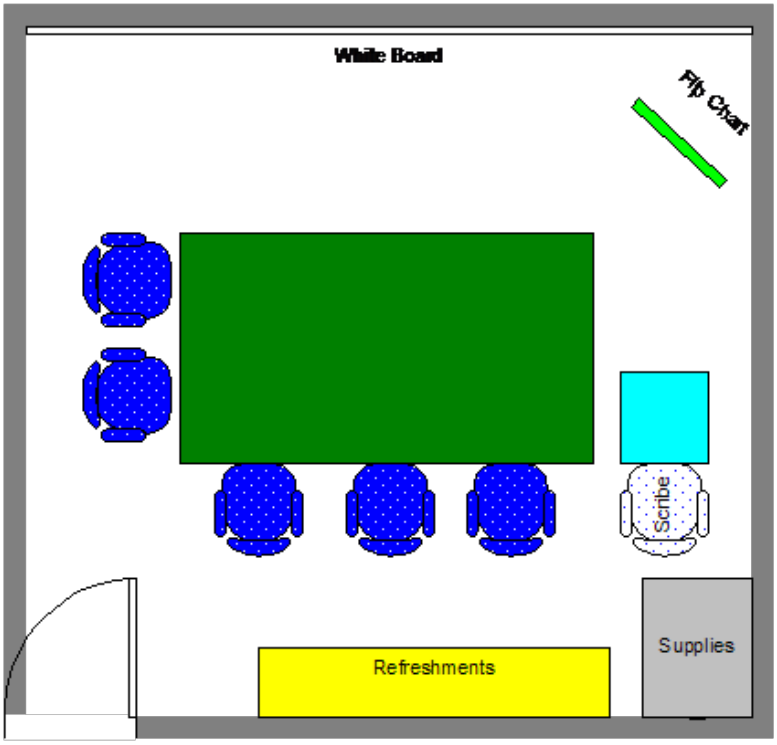

Figure 2-2 Workshop Room Setup

Room Layout – Presenting

The "Present" step of the workshop is a presentation to all of the interested parties on the project. This audience may range from a few individuals to a larger crowd. Generally, a lecture style arrangement is the preferred venue. Depending on the situation, you may want to use the layout below, or choose another from the workshop layouts.

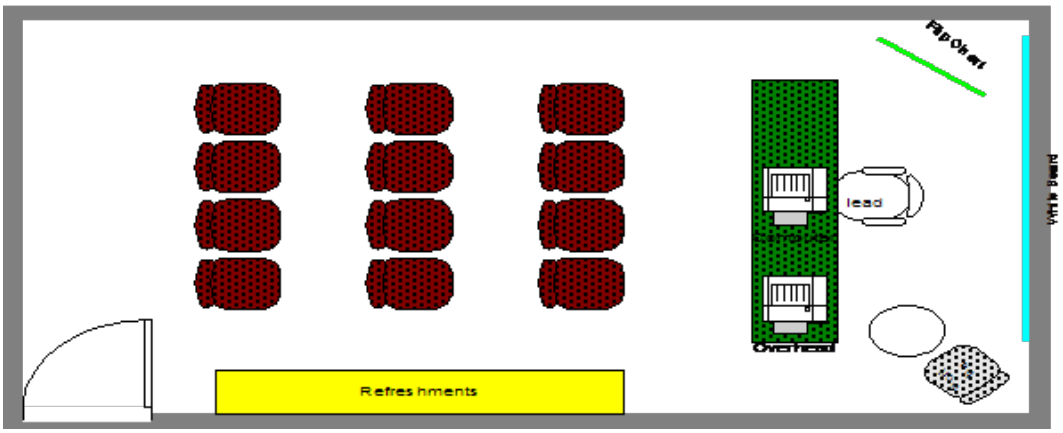

Figure 2-3 Workshop Room Layout - Presenting

Other Considerations

Throughout the course of a workshop, consider the needs of the attendees. These needs include the following:

- regular "comfort breaks" between each activity
- refreshments available at all times
- a light lunch available each day

Suggestion: Avoid heavy lunches, otherwise people become tired afterwards. Avoid having alcohol available during lunch for the same reason, but more so!

CHAPTER

3 Techniques

The techniques described in this chapter support discrete activities that can be used to activities that can be used to construct the overall workshop. Activities commonly workshop. Activities commonly used to construct a workshop are also documented in this chapter. Most activities are supported by specific techniques used to carry out the activity. These techniques are the "toolbox" of the lead consultant. Techniques are chosen for specific reasons — to do a specific job within a workshop, whether baselining, creating a solution or breaking the ice.

The selection of the techniques, and the linking together of activities in a seamless and integrated fashion is the challenge for the lead consultant.

Warning: This handbook assumes that the lead consultant has the necessary experience and knowledge of the underlying concepts that the technique supports. If you are not familiar with a particular concept, do not attempt to use the technique (for example, if you do not understand the ideas behind a value chain, do not attempt to run a value chain analysis activity within a workshop).

Understanding the Customer's Environment

Synopsis

All of the information elicited from attendees at a workshop must be understood in the context of their particular environment. This activity is usually the first within a workshop, to get the attendees to think about the ethos of their work place and begin to identify and highlight the organizational and cultural norms as well as issues, which inhibit performance.

This is the foundation of the picture that they will be building up, against which they can formulate their business or solution objectives.

It is vital for the lead consultant to get as accurate a picture as possible of the customer in order to understand what will and will not work in their particular culture.

It is also useful to begin a workshop session that concentrates on what people are already familiar with, such as their own environment. This will allow everyone to participate immediately, serving to "break the ice" and put people in the right frame of mind to cope with the more difficult issues that lie ahead.

Rationale

This activity is used to accomplish the following:

- gain an understanding of the organizational and cultural norms of the customer's environment
- break the ice, enabling the attendees to begin to form working groups
- begin to gather hints about possible underlying problems

Suggestion: This is a good first activity for any workshop.

Approach

The method for running this activity is as follows:

1. The workshop participants are divided into small groups (depending on size of the total group and room).
2. Each group records impressions on a flip chart, based on one of the approaches shown below.
3. When they have finished writing, each group presents its output to the others, followed by a general discussion — this can lead to items being added.
4. The flip chart is hung on the walls to be referenced throughout the workshop.

Three different approaches can be used to elicit the information:

1. Simply ask them to respond to the following question:

   "What's it like to work here?" The participants will write down their thoughts on a single sheet of flip chart paper.

2. Provide a series of open questions to be answered, such as:

   - What are our strengths?
   - What are our weaknesses?
   - Describe the culture of our organization.
   - What are our values and identity?
   - What has led to our successes so far?
   - How could we do better?

   The participants will answer the questions on a single sheet of flip chart paper.

With more introverted participants, it may be more productive to ask more specific, pointed questions about the project. The participants will duplicate the worksheet on a flip chart, and complete the matrix. A typical worksheet follows:

Considerations	**Assessment**			**Comments**	**Action**
	Y	**N**	**Partial**		
Are the key leaders committed to the project and the changes needed?					
Are informal leaders committed to the project and the changes needed?					
Are leaders willing to invest time in the project?					
Is there a clear vision of the benefits of the project?					
Is there a clear vision of the changes needed to achieve the benefits?					
Is there agreement on the vision and changes needed, especially amongst the leaders?					
Has the vision been communicated to the stakeholders?					
Have the benefits and changes been communicated at all levels?					

Considerations	Assessment			Comments	Action
	Y	N	Partial		
Will there be substantial involvement by those affected?					
Do personnel affected by the project perceive that they are being involved?					
Has a communication plan been developed?					
Are stakeholders prepared for initial impacts?					
Is there an implementation plan that covers all changes to organization, processes and personnel?					

Table 3-1 Typical Worksheet

☞ **Attention:** Carefully select the approach used based on the make-up of the workshop attendees. The questions or worksheets **must** be tailored for a specific workshop.

Output

The output for this activity is a **word picture** of the customer's environment on a flip chart or answers to the questions on the worksheets.

Facilitator's Role

The role of the facilitator is primarily as a passive observer. The facilitator cannot add value when the participants are describing their environment, but may be involved in the following:

- encouraging contributions from all participants
- questioning the participants to make sure that no shallow thinking occurs
- asking the participants to provide further clarification
- keeping track of time

Guidelines

Participants should feel at ease with this activity, but the pitfall is that it is well within their "comfort zone" and most people are happy to continue raking over the past problems and issues. Strictly limit the time available for this activity, and insist on using only one page of a flip chart for presentations thus limiting the overall time.

Timings

Accomplish this activity within the following timescales:

Activity:	20 minutes
Presentations:	5 minutes each
General Discussion:	10 minutes

Hints and Tips

As the initial activity within a workshop, it is the obvious place to begin to set the pace for the rest of the activities. At this time, establish the following workshop standards:

- high work rate
- high concentration
- open discussions
- sharing and building on ideas
- team work

The facilitation and the environment for this activity will assist in maintaining these standards. Supplying the group with only a flip chart and no chairs will focus the team to work around the flip chart as a team, allowing group dynamics to work. By providing chairs, the element of urgency disappears, people relax, and indeed some people can literally take a “back seat” and not involve themselves in the activity.

Value Chain Analysis

Synopsis

Value chain analysis can provide a high-level view of the customer's overall value chain (suppliers, themselves, customers), and highlight any advantages or disadvantages that occur at the interfaces throughout the chain, as illustrated below. The technique of value chain analysis is used to accomplish this activity.

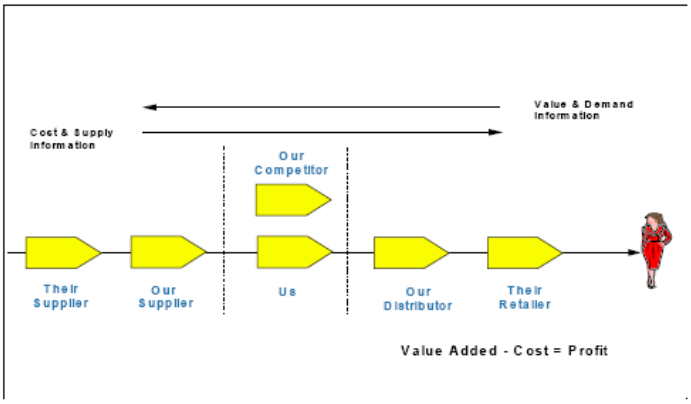

Figure 3-1 Value Chain

It can also be used to develop a high-level process view of the customers' internal value chain, and gain an understanding of the activities performed within these high-level processes, as well as the advantages or disadvantages they contribute to the overall business benefits, as illustrated below.

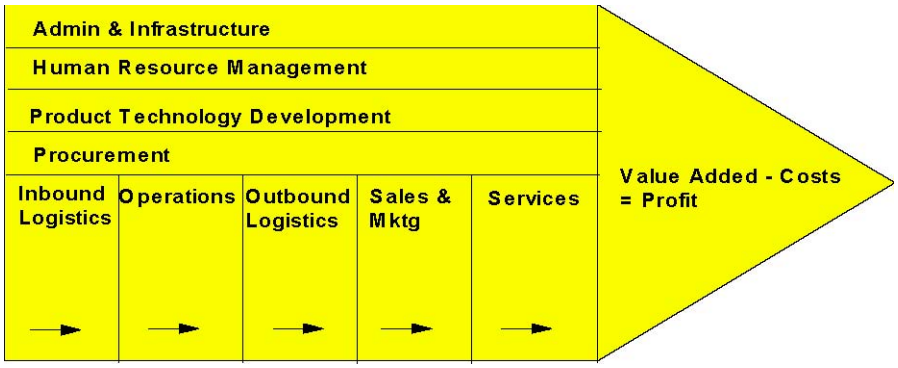

Figure 3-2 Overall Business Benefits

Rationale

Perform a value chain analysis for the following reasons:

- People seldom understand how their company works. They seldom have a vision of the "big picture," and certainly no end-to-end understanding of the overall company.

- Because personnel typically have of an overall view of how their company works, they seldom understand their root cause problems and, therefore, have been trying to fix symptoms.
- Perception is reality — reality is perception. By working in groups we can begin to see the full reality of how a company actually works, and the sharing of participants differing perceptions should come to an agreed view of reality.

Approach

The approach used is determined when this activity is being designed. There are two different approaches to this activity:

1. The entire workshop group works on the overall value chain together.
2. The workshop group is divided into breakout groups, and each group works on one element of the chain.

The first approach is difficult to manage in terms of numbers, but the second approach involves additional complexity in controlling:

- terminology
- level of detail
- duplication of activities
- interfaces
- double counting of advantages

Take this into account while planning the activity, however, the major steps remain the same.

Perform the following steps:

1. Agree on terminology. Are terms "outbound logistics" meaningful to the customer? Agree on the headings for each process in the value chain.
2. Place value chain headings on the brown paper covering the wall.
3. Brainstorm the activities performed within the value chain by writing the activity on a card.
4. Sort the cards. Place associated activities under the relevant headings. Through discussion with the participants agree on the content and appropriate level of detail.
5. Once agreement is achieved, add an "Advantage" heading for each element of the value chain.
6. Either brainstorm or discuss advantages that are achieved under each element of the value chain. Write them on cards and affix them to the chart (equally, if this activity is performed as a baselining activity, it may be applicable to capture any obvious disadvantages).

If breakout groups are used, then further checking must be applied to maintain consistency throughout all groups.

Output

The typical output from a card-based value chain analysis is shown below:

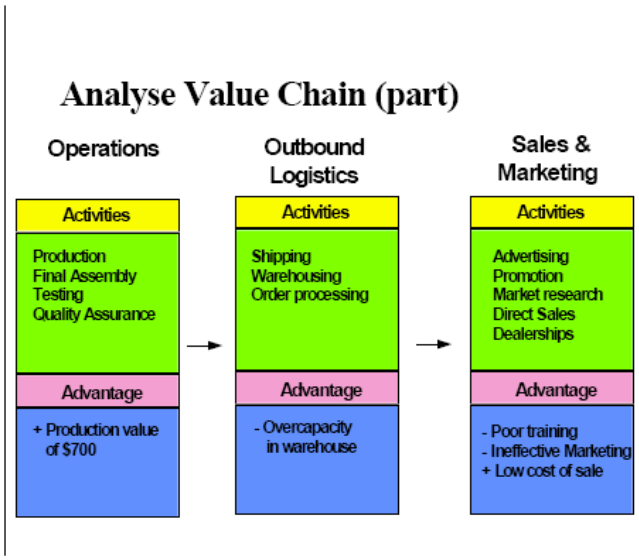

Figure 3-3 Value Chain Analysis Output

Facilitator's Role

The role of the facilitator is to:

- Keep track of time.
- Make sure the activity results in the required output.
- Question whether activities actually reside within a specific element of the value chain and making suggestions of activities that may be missed.
- Make sure we maintain the right and appropriate level of detail.
- Check that the participants view the value chain as a process, rather than as organizational functions.
- Challenge and question the participants on the advantages they identify.

Guidelines

The critical aspects of this activity revolve around two issues:

- analysis of the value chain — a single group, or break-out groups
- an agreed on and understood color coding of cards (headings, activities, advantages)

Timings

A detailed value chain analysis for a company may take many weeks of intensive effort; however, to provide an initial baseline, it is possible to run this activity in a workshop in approximately one hour.

Hints and Tips

When using this technique within a workshop environment, consider the following:

- Value chain analysis looks at processes within an organization, not necessarily the functional organization. The participants may have problems in divorcing these concepts. For example, Operations, as a process, is usually very different from the Manufacturing Department.
- In applying this technique, make sure that the right and appropriate level of detail is common across the value chain. For example, do not list activities like "Manufacture" in one column, and another activity, "Validate Purchase Order," in another column. The first is too high-level, the second is too detailed.
- When dealing with the advantages or disadvantages, it may be difficult to identify actual dollar values. This would need to be done in a detailed value chain analysis for a customer, but you may want to consider qualitative advantages or disadvantages (for example, +*ve Low cost of sale*).

Vulnerability Analysis

Synopsis

Use the vulnerability analysis technique to analyze an organization's vulnerability in terms of major changes in the environment in which it operates. Although this technique is generally employed within the strategic planning environment, it can successfully be employed to gather baseline information about the customer and its view of the commercial world.

The technique considers what supportive elements, if suddenly taken away, might seriously damage or even destroy the business.

Use the following questions to determine which areas of underpinnings to consider:

1. Are the customer needs and wants served by the product or service?
2. What are the resources and assets involved, including people, capital, facilities, raw materials, and technological know-how?
3. What is the cost position relative to competition (by major cost components)?
4. What is the consumer base, including size, demographics, and trends?
5. What are the technology requirements?
6. What special skills, systems, procedures, and organization are required?
7. What is the corporate identity, including logo, image, products, corporate culture, and role models?
8. What are the institutional barriers to competition, including regulations, codes, patent laws, and licensing?
9. What are the social values, including lifestyles, common norms, and ideals?
10. What are the sanctions, supports and incentives to do business, particularly in such fields as medicine, restaurants, securities, import-export, nuclear or arms?
11. What is the effect on building customer goodwill, including product safety, product quality, and company reputation?
12. What are the complimentary products or services in the stakeholder system?
13. Are there any other underpinnings?

Rationale

The rationale is to gather baseline information about the external environment for the customer, and their readiness to absorb change. This technique forces the participants to think about issues outside of their normal day-to-day operations.

Approach

Follow the seven steps below:

1. Identify or agree on underpinnings.
2. State how removal of an underpinning would threaten the business.
3. State the most conservative consequence of each threat.
4. Rank the impact of worst consequences of each threat (0 - no impact, 10 - catastrophic).
5. Estimate the probability that each threat will materialize.
6. Rank the company's ability to deal with each threat, should it materialize (0 - defenselessness, 10 - easily absorb the blow).
7. Determine whether the company's vulnerability to each threat is extreme or negligible (vulnerability assessment graph).

This activity can be performed by the entire workshop group, or divided into two or three breakout groups. Use of breakout groups require the additional step of presenting the findings to the entire workshop group followed by a general discussion by the entire group.

Use the following table to complete the required data:

Assumptions	Threat	Consequence	Impact 0-10	Probability 0-1	Capability 0-10	Vulnerability Assessment
1. Needs and wants served by product						
2. Resources and assets						
3. Cost position relative to competition						
4. Customer base						
5. Technologies						
6. Special skills						
7. Corporate identity						
8. Institutional barriers to competition						
9. Social values						
10. Sanctions, supports and incentives						
11. Customer goodwill						
12. Complementary products or services						
13. Other						

Table 3-2 Vulnerability Analysis Information

Use the above table as a template to gather information.

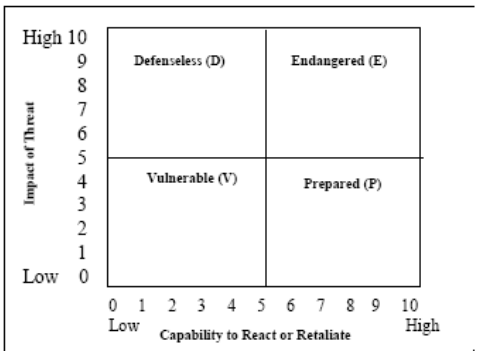

Figure 3-4 Vulnerability Matrix

Place each underpinning on the above matrix for visual impact. The following classification will help identify any actions that need to be performed:

- Defenseless - requires immediate attention
- Endangered - reduces the impact
- Prepared - no monitoring required
- Vulnerable - plan for contingencies and monitor threats

Output

Assumptions	Beliefs	Consequence	Impact 0-10	Probability 0-1	Capability 0-10	Vulnerability Assessment
1. Needs and wants served by product	Information Processing	Compete with clones and others	9	0.9	7	E
2. Resources and assets	Large and Available	Current Losses	9	0.9	6	E
3. Cost position relative to competition	Recognized leader	Loss of position	6	.5	5	V
4. Customer base	World-wide	Difficult sales	8	0.6	8	E
5. Technologies	Superior leader	Fallen behind	9	0.6	9	E
6. Special skills	Sales and service	cannot hold sales	8	0.5	8	E
7. Corporate identity	Best managed company	Layoffs, restructure	5	0.8	6	P
8. Institutional barriers to competition	Corporate accounts	Changing base	7	0.6	8	E
9. Social values	Lifetime job and care	Overhead expense	5	0.3	8	P
10. Sanctions, supports and incentives	Large sales of mainframes	Declining market	8	0.8	6	E
11. Customer goodwill	Proud of service	Changing expectations	5	0.5	5	V
12. Complementary products or services	Software, minicomputers	Failed in software, AS400	7	0.8	6	E
13. Other						

Table 3-3 Vulnerability Analysis Output

Facilitator's Role

The role of the facilitator is to provide the participants with the necessary guidelines and assistance in driving the activity to a successful conclusion.

In addition, the facilitator may be called on to be an "expert," who gives advice based on previous experience or expert knowledge.

Guidelines

This type of technique can be difficult to apply in a workshop environment. The main pitfalls are:

- The participants must be capable of understanding and envisioning the impact of the external environment.
- The participants must have a broad working knowledge of their company, and the inter-relationships between internal functions and their interfaces into the broader business environment.
- The facilitator must be able to provide real-world examples of customers or other case-study material that can be used to help stretch the imagination of the participants. The experience and examples the facilitator will bring to this activity must include industry specific examples.

Complete significant planning and preparation (on both sides) prior to embarking on this activity.

Timings

Depending on the type of result required, the timescales vary as follows:

Detailed Vulnerability Analysis:	1 day
Baseline Information Only:	1.5 hours

This does not include the significant preparation and research required prior to the workshop.

Hints and Tips

Fully brief the participants at least one week before the workshop. Provide the templates to the participants and ask them to complete them prior to attending the workshop.

Brainstorming

Synopsis

Brainstorming is a technique used for the generation, collection, and documentation of ideas that are required for a workshop.

Rationale

This technique is used to accomplish the following:

- generate raw ideas
- highlight alternative approaches
- use "out of the box" thinking

Approach

Two simple brainstorming approaches can be used during a workshop:

- unstructured
- structured

Unstructured

The unstructured approach is usually performed in the following manner:

1. Select one person as a scribe (not the facilitator!).
2. Pose a question for the participants (such as, "What are the benefits to the business if we introduce NCA?").
3. Encourage the participants to shout out their ideas.
4. Have the scribe write them on a flip chart.

Once the ideas dry up, the brainstorming session is complete.

One of the drawbacks of unstructured brainstorming is peer pressure resulting from the following:

- People are shy or they do not want to look foolish in front of other people.
- Dominant personalities can suppress other people's ideas.
- The scribe can unconsciously filter ideas.

A more formal, democratic approach is usually more welcomed — structured brainstorming.

Structured

Structured brainstorming uses a similar approach, but ideas are privately considered by the participants, and then anonymously contributed, hence removing the problems associated with unstructured brainstorming.

The approach is relatively simple:

1. Hand each participant a number of cards (three is the norm) and a felt-tip pen.
2. Pose a question for the participants (such as, "What are the benefits to the business if we introduce NCA?").
3. Ask the participants to consider the question, and write their ideas (clearly and legibly) — one for each card.
4. Collect the cards and affix them to brown paper on the wall.
5. Once everyone has finished, ask them to consider the output.
6. Issue another card to each participant and ask them to submit one last idea. This enables gaps to be filled, or quality to be increased.
7. Collect the additional cards and affix them to the existing chart.

Once the brainstorming session is complete, sort the cards into common groups or themes. Two sorting approaches can be used:

- facilitator-led
- silent

Facilitator-Led Sorting

The approach used is as follows:

1. The facilitator selects a card at random.
2. The participants are asked, “Is there another card similar to this?”
3. The participants identify similar cards.
4. The facilitator will group them together.
5. Once three or four cards have been identified, the facilitator will ask, “What do you think the name of this group is?”
6. After discussion by the participants, they will agree on a group name. The facilitator will write the group heading on an oval card, and place it above the group of idea cards.
7. The facilitator will then ask if any further cards belong to this group, and continue until this group is complete.
8. The facilitator selects a new card, and returns to step 2.

Facilitator-led sorting is quite dynamic and group headings may change over the period of the sorting. New groups may occur by combining smaller groups, old groups may split into other new groups as the participants begin to assimilate the cards and understand the relationship to each other.

One of the major benefits of using this approach is to generate discussion about the points raised during the sorting session; however, this can also cause the sorting session to become lengthy. One way of reducing the length of time is through silent sorting.

Silent Sorting

Silent sorting uses a similar approach to facilitator-led sorting, but the participants sort the cards into groups themselves, and they write the group headings. Complete the whole sorting session in total silence (policed by the facilitator) so that arguments do not occur (for example, "The reason this card belongs to this group is....").

This approach allows for rapid sorting of cards, but obviously does not generate discussion, so the facilitator may wish to lead a discussion about the groupings once the sorting is complete.

Output

The result of a typical brainstorming session is shown below.

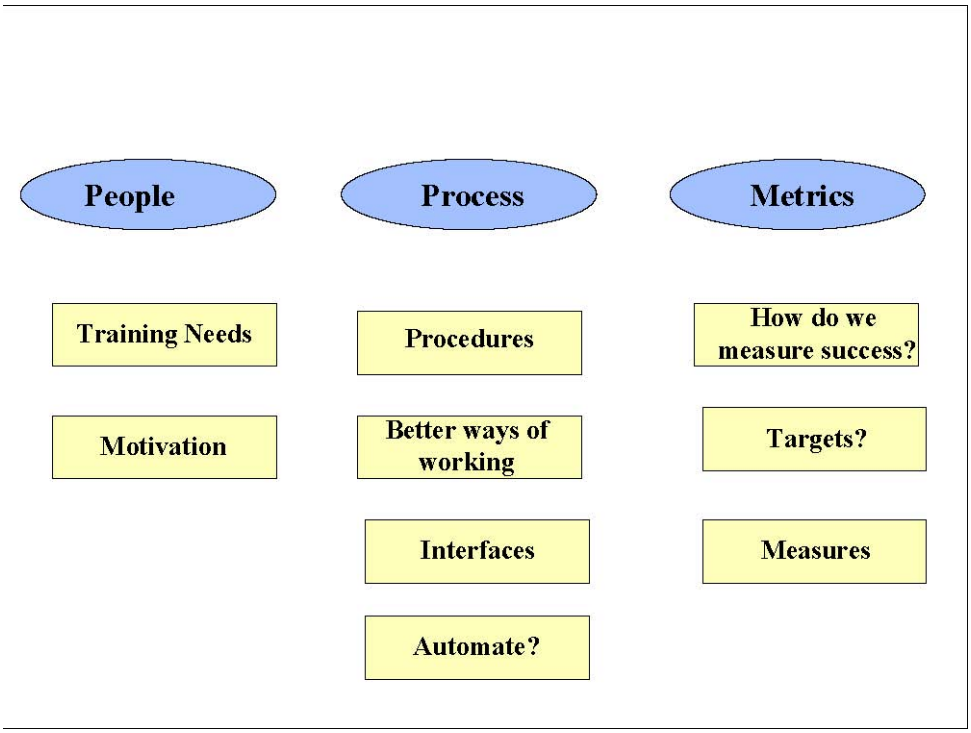

Figure 3-5 Typical Brainstorming Session

The oval cards are the groups, and the rectangular cards are the ideas that have been sorted into the groups.

Facilitator's Role

During a brainstorming session, the facilitator must never lead the session, bias it in any way, or steer it to a conclusion other than the group's own. As such, the role of the facilitator is to:

- Drive the mechanics of the session.
- Make sure that ideas are generated, grouped and recorded in the given timescale.

Guidelines

Tailor the brainstorming sessions to get the right results for the customer, and provide enough variety in approaches so as not to become boring. The following variants can be used to provide variety to the workshop.

1. The facilitator selects a card at random. In an unstructured brainstorming session, it is always difficult to produce group headings. An alternative variant on this is to use pre-determined headings on several flip charts:
   - organization or business model
   - people
   - process
   - metrics
   - tools and resources

   Another variant is not to use a scribe, but the whole group can write on the flip charts simultaneously.
1. Ideas cards can be color-coded to provide additional information. For example, a standard brainstorming session for obstacles and enablers would use two colored cards:
   - green to collect enabler information
   - pink to collect obstacle information
2. In a structured brainstorming session under pre-defined headings, agree on the headings beforehand, and write them onto oval cards. Request that the participants consider their ideas under the specific group headings. As the participant writes a card, he places the card under the appropriate group heading.

Timings

The duration of a brainstorming session depends upon the approach used, and the number of ideas generated. Keeping this in mind, use the following timings:

Brainstorming the Ideas:	20 minutes
Silent Sorting:	5 minutes
Facilitator-Led Sorting:	30-60 minutes

Hints and Tips

The success of any brainstorming session depends upon the quality of the ideas generated; make sure the group has a number of “idea people” who can contribute to these activities.

Select the appropriate approach, based on expected output. For example, if you want to generate a high volume of ideas (maybe 200300), do not select facilitator-led sorting. This

could take two hours, and the participants' attention span will last a maximum of half-an-hour!

Always emphasize the quality of output, rather than the quantity of output.

Do not stifle the participants' creativity by:

- criticizing
- offering suggestions or advice for ideas
- using inappropriate techniques for the group

Once the ideas are beginning to dwindle, re-energize the group with comments such as, "Does this have an impact on people? Have we considered this?" The facilitator should suggest areas for them to consider, not give them their ideas.

Encourage attendees to write in large letters, legibly, and in short, meaningful phrases (a maximum of six words) so that all cards can be easily read.

Influence Diagramming

Synopsis

Influence diagramming takes complex issues and investigates all the interrelated factors. It is a visual representation of the logical (and often causal) relationships between these factors.

Rationale

In a workshop designed to produce a solution, the following steps usually occur:

1. Identify current situation.
2. Brainstorm ideas for a future solution.
3. Set solution objectives.
4. Identify critical success factors and prerequisites.
5. Develop of solution.

In a complex solution environment, problems occur at steps 3 and 4 above — trying to understand the interrelationships between objectives, critical success factors and prerequisites. Prior to embarking on these activities, influence diagramming can help summarize these relationships and help speed up and increase the quality of the activities.

Approach

The approach uses the entire group.

Influence Diagrams are best developed through the use of Post-It Notes ("yellow stickies") or cards. This allows the creators to move things around in the overall diagram without having to rewrite the whole thing Flip charts are inappropriate for this kind of activity, as more space is needed.

1. Confirm the issue and solution you are considering and write the heading on a flip chart.
2. Generate and display sub-headings of the issue:
   - sub-headings could be the existing group headings from the previous brainstorming activity
   - additional sub-headings may be brainstormed with the group
   - generic sub-headings may be generated beforehand (People, Processes, Organization, Quality, etc.) and can be discussed and used if appropriate

   Place the sub-headings on a display area.

3. This step considers the relationship of each sub-heading with every other sub-heading. This is achieved by the following:
   - Select the first sub-heading, and ask the question of the next sub-heading, "*Does the first sub-heading cause or influence the second one?*"
   - If the answer is yes, draw an arrow from the first subheading to the second using an arrowhead to show the direction of influence.
   - Repeat this for the first sub-heading for every other subheading.
   - Repeat the last three steps for each other sub-heading.
4. Review and revise the draft influence diagram. Check that all links are complete, and revise if necessary.
5. Interpret the influence diagram, and identify key sub-headings.
   - Identify which arrows are coming out of a box — if this were removed, it would reduce a large number of other items.
   - Identify which arrows have the most going into a box — a bottleneck to the reduction of a problem or production of a solution.
   - Identify the sub-heading which has the highest total of arrows connected to it — a central activity - pivotal.
6. Use a different color card or Post-It Note to identify key subheadings.

Output

A typical influence diagram is shown below:

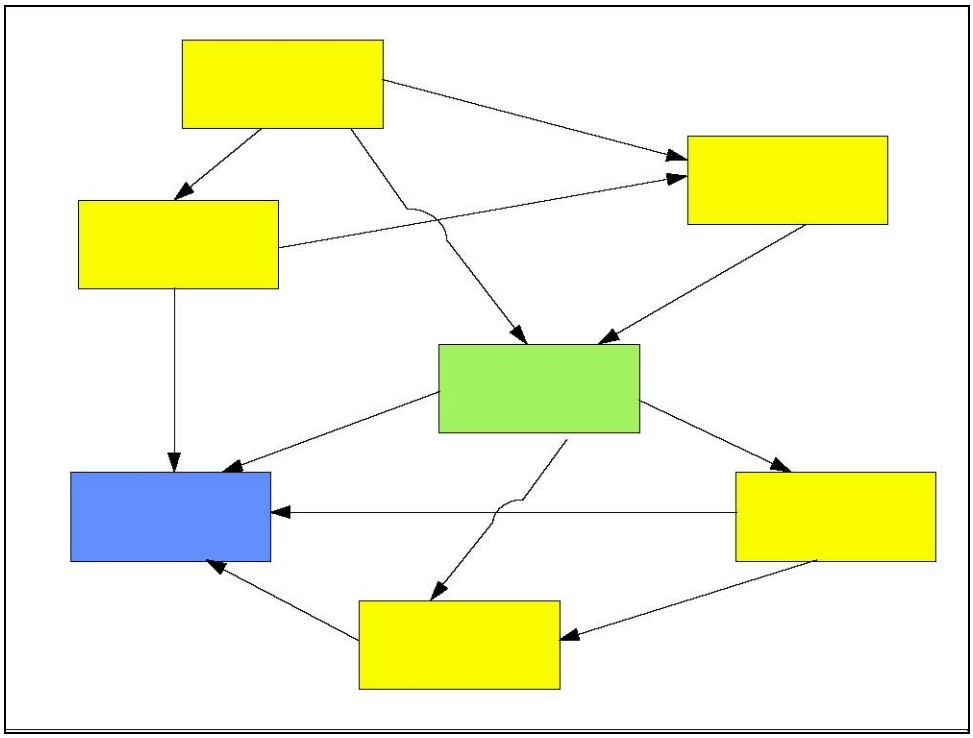

Figure 3-6 Influence Diagram

Facilitator's Role

The role of the facilitator is to:

- Facilitate the brainstorming sessions.
- Encourage free discussion, but suppress "hair splitting" which causes fluidity of the process to be lost.
- Keep the group on-track.

Guidelines

It is the discussion about the direction of the arrow that leads to an understanding and agreement on what is the cause or influence that needs to be addressed. The group is then clearly focused on what key items need to be highlighted. Do not compromise with two-way arrows.

Keep the number of sub-headings on the influence diagram to a manageable number (maximum of 10-12). An increase in sub-headings, increases elapsed time exponentially.

Timings

The approximate timings for this activity (if done as a high-level activity, as described in the Rationale section) are:

Agree on Heading:	5 minutes
Generate Subheadings:	10 minutes
Develop Relationships:	60 minutes (assuming 10 subheadings)
Interpret Diagram :	15 minutes

Hints and Tips

Influence diagramming could form a whole workshop in itself. If, for example, we are trying to identify problems within an organization, then the influence diagramming technique could be used to identify the issues you need to expose. However, this could result in 100-200 subheadings being generated, which could require several days to map out completely.

When using cards and brown paper, think about how to represent arrows. If you use a felt-tip pen to draw the arrows, then you lose the flexibility when sub-heading cards have to be moved around to avoid arrows drawn over other cards.

Setting Objectives

Synopsis

The purpose of this activity is to provide a focus for any prior study and to understand the value the customer will place on changes and improvements. In order to justify any recommendations for making specific improvements, it is first necessary to understand what the customer is ultimately trying to achieve, or what they have been asked to achieve by a higher level of the organization. This will determine what areas need to be improved on and, hence, the direction of the study.

Without this kind of activity in a workshop, it will be difficult, if not impossible, to justify any expenditure, and certainly not possible to measure the impact of changes which take place.

Rationale

This technique is used to accomplish the following:

- set the direction of a particular study
- understand the value of making a change

Approach

The approach for setting objectives is as follows:

1. It may be necessary at this stage to discuss what is meant by "objective" in this context, as there may be some confusion about terms such as: mission, objective, goal. Each company has its own way of defining these concepts and all that is necessary here is that participants should clearly understand what is being asked of them.
2. With the basic terminology understood, we must gain an agreement of the level of detail of an objective. These range from very high-level "motherhood" statements, such as, "We will delight our customer," down to, "Desktop PCs will have the following specification...." It is essential that the right level of objectives is needed, and that the participants agree on the level of detail.
3. Split the overall group into smaller breakout groups of three or four people.
4. Ask each group to develop specific objectives for certain areas. These areas may be the group headings from a brainstorming session, or other areas that have been predefined.
5. Once the objectives have been documented, each breakout group will present to the others, making notes on any comments, disagreements, and additional ideas.

6. Once all objectives have been presented, lead a discussion considering the following:
   - Have any objectives been missed?
   - Should we consider any other aspects?
7. Return to breakout groups for an update of the original objectives based on feedback, and the crafting of any additional objectives required.
8. Hang the objectives on the wall.
9. It may be appropriate to prioritize objectives in terms of priority or importance to the overall project.

Output

The output from these sessions will be a series of flip charts with an objective stated in terms of time and value on each sheet.

Facilitator's Role

The role of the facilitator is to guide the groups in identifying specific objectives. It is very difficult to separate "means" from "ends," although these distinctions are not absolute and the means of one level become the ends of the next level down. People often put up statements that are not objectives but the means to achieve an objective (for example, developing a marketing strategy may be a means to achieving greater market share). By gentle, persistent, and specific questioning, the facilitator can lead the groups into identifying what the actual desired ends are for them.

Guidelines

The facilitator should try to get the groups to make the objectives measurable in time and value (and if this activity is performed with senior customer management, they may be setting "stretch targets"). This is another way of testing the objectives (means versus end), by applying measures in time and value. It is very difficult to measure success against vague statements and, in the future, it should be possible to demonstrate the success of the objective implemented.

Timings

Experience suggests that a breakout group can discuss, agree on, assign value and time, and document an objective in about 15 minutes. This is based on an average. It may take half-an-hour to create the first one, whilst the participants are coming to terms with the level of detail they need, and then the process begins to speed up.

Hints and Tips

When the participants are trying to determine the value of the objective, the facilitator can assist by prompting them as follows:

- How can this objective reduce costs?
- How can this objective reduce costs?

Once they broadly identify the areas to focus on, the facilitator can get them to provide more detail by prompting them as follows:

- How many Full Time Equivalents (FTEs) would this release? What is the average salary of an FTE?
- How many new sales calls could now be made? What is the value of a typical sales call?

Although the participants are unlikely to have accurate information at hand, ballpark figures can illustrate the value of a particular objective adequately. Refine any objective phrased in terms of value at a later date. Validate the values stated.

Always avoid values represented as percentages. The objective, "Reduce re-issue of credit notes by 95% within 1 month," on the surface looks quite aggressive and welcome, until we find out that the customer only has to re-issue 50 credit notes a year!

Tree Diagramming

Synopsis

Tree diagramming is a technique that systematically maps out, in increasing levels of detail, the full range of paths and tasks that need to be accomplished in order to achieve a primary objective and every sub-objective.

Rationale

This technique is used to accomplish the following:

- to breakdown an objective into increasing levels of detail until action steps can be identified
- to be used in conjunction with the objective setting activity to make sure the correct level of objectives are set (by comparison to other objectives or sub-objectives on the tree)

Approach

A series of objectives may need to be broken down into a series of action steps, so this kind of work will probably be done in parallel working groups.

Tree diagrams are best developed through the use of Post-It Notes (yellow stickies) or cards. This enables the creators to move things around in the overall diagram without having to rewrite the whole thing. Flip charts are inappropriate for this kind of activity, as more space is needed.

1. Select the objective, and write it on a card, and place it in column.
2. Use a brainstorming technique to ask the question, "What needs to happen, to be addressed, or to be resolved in order to achieve the objective statement?" Write these on cards or Post-It Notes.
3. After discussion, the brainstormed ideas will be reduced to a small number. These are sub-objectives, and are placed in column 2. The other cards will be kept to one side, as they may form sub-objectives, or action steps in columns 3 or 4.
4. Each column 2 sub-objective is considered in exactly the same way as steps 2 and 3 above.
5. This iterative process continues until each column 2 sub-objectives are broken down into manageable action steps (or even measures). This may result in three or even four levels of the tree diagram — 4 columns.
6. The output is tested for logic and realism:
   - from right to left — "Will the actions in this column lead to the results in the previous column?" Reiterate until you reach the objective.
   - from left to right — "If I want to accomplish these results, do I really need to do these tasks?

Output

A typical output to three levels is shown below:

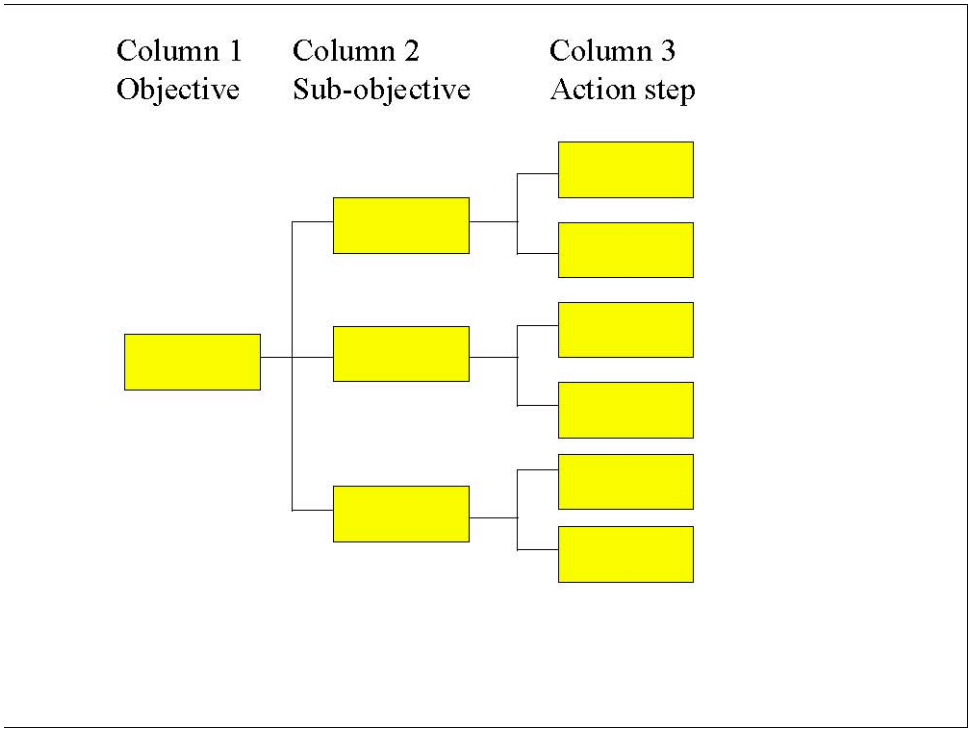

Figure 3-7 Typical Tree Diagram Output

Facilitator's Role

The role of the facilitator is to:

- Facilitate the brainstorming sessions.
- Make sure the appropriate level of detail is maintained throughout each column.
- Keep the teams on-track.

Guidelines

The success of this activity depends on a number of factors:

- Choose the right team.
  - The groups must have a good knowledge of what is required to action the objective.
  - The right size of group (4-6 people is the optimum). If the group is too large, each brainstorming session will generate a large number of ideas, which take time to reduce to the next level of sub-objectives.
  - Always include an attendee who is prepared to slay "sacred cows."

- Choose the right objective for the tree diagram. The best way to gauge success in a tree diagram is that the end-column (right hand side) must show statements that are actionable.

Timings

The timings for this activity purely depend upon the levels of sub-objectives in each column, and the number of columns required to drive the objective down to actions.

Hints and Tips

The facilitator must make sure that the objective for the tree diagram is appropriate for decomposition down to actionable statements. If you set it at too high a level, you could become swamped with information.

If after brainstorming the initial objective, column 2 ends up with 15 sub-objectives, and in turn each sub objectives result in 5-10 other sub-objectives, and these could be broken down into 5-10 actions, and you are using standard-sized cards, then the height of column 4 could be 15m! If this kind of decomposition is occurring, then the overall activity should be broken down into more manageable chunks.

When using cards and brown paper, think about how the links between columns are shown. You will lose the flexibility if you use a felt-tip pen to draw the links. Alternatives may include using cotton yarn to link the cards together, or even using various card colors to help differentiate.

Identifying CSFs and Prerequisites

Synopsis

Once having developed an objective or principle during a workshop, there is now an opportunity to consider any dependencies or criticalities in terms of adopting the objective. The areas we generally consider are:

- any critical success factors (CSFs) — The few key areas where "things must go right" for the objective to be successfully adopted.
- the metrics — The measures used to quantify performance of the critical success factors. (What gets measured, gets done.)
- any prerequisites — The things that need to be put in place for the objective to be attained.

The workshop activity will result in the relevant CSFs, metrics and prerequisites of achieving (POA) the objective.

Rationale

With the direction provided by the objectives, this activity can provide additional information that can assist in appreciating the overall scope of the project. For example:

- Identify the conditions that must exist before the business objectives can be achieved.
- Identify additional opportunities for the facilitating organization.
- Identify inter-dependencies.
- Highlight additional activities.

Approach

Perform this activity as an entire group, or in individual groups. The approach is the same for both:

1. An objective is selected on which to work.
2. The group considers the critical success factors of this objective.
3. The group considers the metrics used to measure the CSFs.
4. The group considers the prerequisites of achieving the objectives.
5. Document everything along with the objective.

If these are developed in breakout groups, then presentation, discussion and further updating will be required.

Output

The output from these sessions will be a series of flip charts that contain an objective stated in terms of time and value on each sheet along with their associated CSFs metrics and POAs.

Facilitator's Role

The role of the facilitator is to:

- Differentiate between CSFs and POAs.
- Identify appropriate metrics for CSFs.
- Verify that only vital POAs are selected.
- Select only the critical and dispensable CSFs and POAs.

Guidelines

Critical success factors are generally found in the following areas:

- strategic direction
- customer satisfaction (internal and external)
- cost control or productivity
- management or business capability
- human resource management
- cultural or attitude change
- system and control (which includes information systems)
- external affairs or regulatory
- product quality and innovation
- product operations

Once the CSFs have been identified, it is essential to identify the metrics used to quantify the performance of each CSF. It provides an opportunity to set up a mechanism for monitoring the metrics, and provide regular reporting throughout the project.

Timings

The complexity of the customer's environment and the objectives being developed will determine the time required to provide all the information for one objective. A good rule of thumb for planning purposes is 20 minutes for each objective covered.

Hints and Tips

Identification of CSFs is seldom attained by asking the question, "What are the CSFs?" but rather with the following questions:

- If you were presented with a free day of time, what would you do with it?
- What keeps you awake at night?
- After a holiday, what three questions would you ask upon your return?
- If you could change, or make two things happen in your business, what would they be?
- If someone said, "I've got bad news for you," what would you least like it to be?

The POAs sometimes becomes a lengthy list. This should be reduced down to the things that are critical, that is, "the things without which you cannot achieve this objective" rather than things "nice to have."

Voting and Prioritization

Synopsis

During any workshop, there will come a point when the following decisions have to be made:

- We have 20 objectives, which ones should we concentrate on?
- What is the highest priority on this list?
- Which one should we address first?

We need a simple mechanism to make these decisions quickly without having to enter into long discussions. Simple voting and prioritization should only be used for trivial decisions within a workshop. For example, deciding among three alternative IS strategies that will support the customer's globalization plans over the next five years, should not be put to a simple vote!

Rationale

These simple techniques allow workshop attendees to quickly make decisions on priority and importance, and help avoid lengthy discussions and getting "bogged-down" due to the inability of a group to come to an agreement.

Approach

Various approaches can be used, either in open forum, or secretly, when you suspect more senior people may influence junior personnel.

Simple Voting

Simple voting techniques include:

- show of hands
- secret ballot

These techniques are appropriate for eliciting yes or no answers.

Prioritization

Simple techniques for prioritizing a list include:

- Provide 5-7 "sticky dots" and ask the attendees to use them as votes against the list. The attendees could use all the dots for one particular element on the list, or spread them around. Once all of the attendees have cast their votes, prioritize the list based on the number of dots placed by each element.

- Similarly, each attendee is told that if they could spend $100 on the elements of the prioritized list, how would they spend the money? Again, the priorities are indicated by the value of money spent associated to them.

This approach can be used in open forum, and done in secret. The private prioritization can be achieved by turning the flip chart away from the other attendees (or indeed putting the flip chart in another room) and asking each attendee to cast their votes in private (well, almost in private — the second person to vote will know how the first person cast theirs!)

Output

The outputs are:

- yes or no decision
- prioritized list

Facilitator's Role

The role of the facilitator is to:

- Decide which approach to voting or prioritizing is appropriate.
- Manage the process to make sure it runs smoothly and fairly.

Guidelines

none

Timings

The approximate timings for these activities are:

Simple Voting:		1 minute
Private Ballot	:	5 minutes
Prioritizing List:		5 minutes

Hints and Tips

Use appropriate techniques for the results you need. For example, if you require a yes or no answer, avoid any technique that may result in a draw. For example, if a simple show of hands results in a draw, do not use another technique that may end up with the same result!

You cannot achieve this objective" rather than things "nice to have."

Delphi Technique

Synopsis

The delphi technique is a method of developing and improving group consensus. This technique has been evolved for a workshop driven approach, and allows a “ball park” consensus to be achieved quickly, particularly if you are interested in numerical data.

Rationale

If numerical data is being considered, and there is disagreement, this technique can help build consensus quickly. The key to its success is assuring the participants anonymity during the early stages, which helps people “give-ground” and come to a more agreed on figure.

Approach

As an example, during a workshop, we are trying to understand some of the business benefits in introducing NCA within the customer's organization. It is thought that savings could be made through the use of mobile agents technology in the sales force, but we are having difficulty agreeing on typical sales figures projected over the next five years — not that we have a feel for the figures, just a disagreement in size.

The approach used is as follows:

1. As with the normal brainstorming card technique, pose an appropriate question:

   “What is our sales revenue of product xxx in 2005?”

2. Issue pens and cards and ask the attendees to write down their estimate.
3. Display the estimates for all to see on a pre-drawn matrix (an overhead projector is ideal for this purpose).
4. Do not allow any discussion. Allow some time for contemplation and get the participants to make a new estimate. Again display the estimates.

   You may repeat this silent approach for a few iterations. Keep all the data on display.

5. Then ask someone to suggest why the highest number is incorrect and ask someone to suggest why the lowest number is incorrect.
6. Get participants to re-estimate.
7. Introduce general discussion.
8. Get participants to re-estimate.
9. Have a final discussion and final re-estimate.

Consider using a statistical technique to smooth any differences. You must get group approval to do this. If you calculate a mean, it is generally a good idea to also show the standard deviation so that you honor the extreme estimates.

Output

The output is an agreed on estimate.

Facilitator's Role

The role of the facilitator is to:

- Make sure that the group strictly adheres to the rules of the technique.
- Write the figures on the slide and present them to the attendees.
- Select the two people to ask the questions.
- Lead any discussions about the figures.

Guidelines

This technique works best on numerical data, and the approach must be adhered to strictly. If in the initial iterations of estimation, and people publicly declare their preferred estimate, they will entrench their position, and never move from that estimate. The silent iterations allow them to change their position without losing face.

Timings

Limiting the discussions to only a few minutes will enable completing the whole process within 20 minutes.

Hints and Tips

Although this may seem a long-winded approach just to get agreement on a single number, twenty minutes is a worthwhile investment in time if the alternative is hours of arguing, and no productive activities.

Credits

The delphi technique was originally developed and used within the Rand Corporation.

Wallcharting

Synopsis

Wallcharting is a technique that enables attendees to develop solutions in groups. Wallcharting can be applied to any of the following kinds of activity as long as they are being developed in a workshop environment:

- Describe the study objectives.
- Develop a project plan.
- Describe a process flow.
- Describe an information flow.
- Perform task analysis.
- Perform issue or problem analysis.
- Capture solution ideas.

This list is not complete. Wallcharting can be used with any other activity you can dream up. The flexibility and simplicity of this technique lends itself to the design of any solution.

Rationale

Building solutions in groups can provides the following significant benefits:

- employs the benefits of group dynamics
- is faster than traditional approaches
- builds consensus
- can be fun (which is a real benefit when trying to build team spirit)
- uses simple tools, so anyone can be involved
- makes it easy to change the design or contents
- allows the whole group to take part
- enables “strangers” to evaluate or validate the work — the use of visual images allow for easy assimilation and understanding of the outputs

Approach

Wallcharting uses simple tools — cards, brown paper and mounting spray (or even a flip chart and Post It Notes).

The first step is to cover a wall with brown paper:

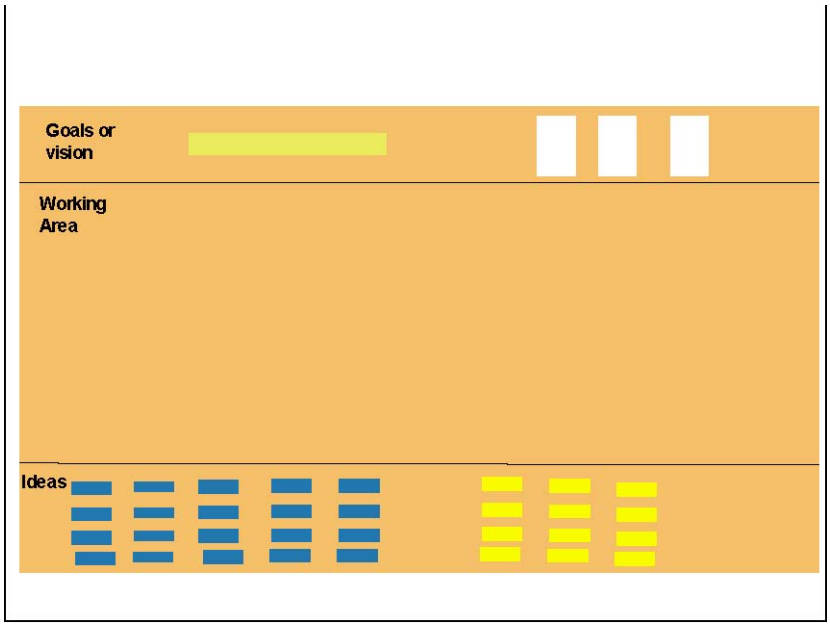

Figure 3-8 Brown Paper Diagram

The brown paper is divided into three areas:

Top: Display the objectives of the study, so it is always available to focus the attendees' minds. You may also want to display any important messages from the project sponsor.

Bottom: This is the "ideas bank". While working on any wallcharting activity, any ideas and thoughts are written on cards and held in the bottom area so that no idea is ever lost.

Middle: This is the working area for developing the solution.

The next step is to agree on a set of wallcharting conventions:

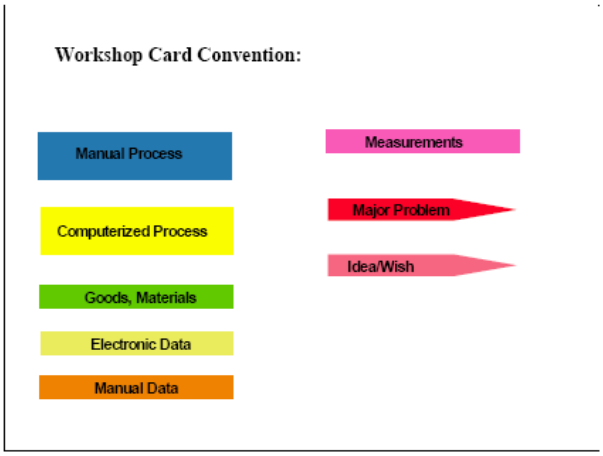

Figure 3-9 Wallcharting Conventions

Tailor the wallcharting convention to the specific solution being developed. The convention will be made available to all attendees throughout the workshop session.

The solution will then be developed. A series of activities will be used to build up the solution. The result of each activity will be displayed on the wallchart, move from left to right, building up the solution, showing all intermediary steps.

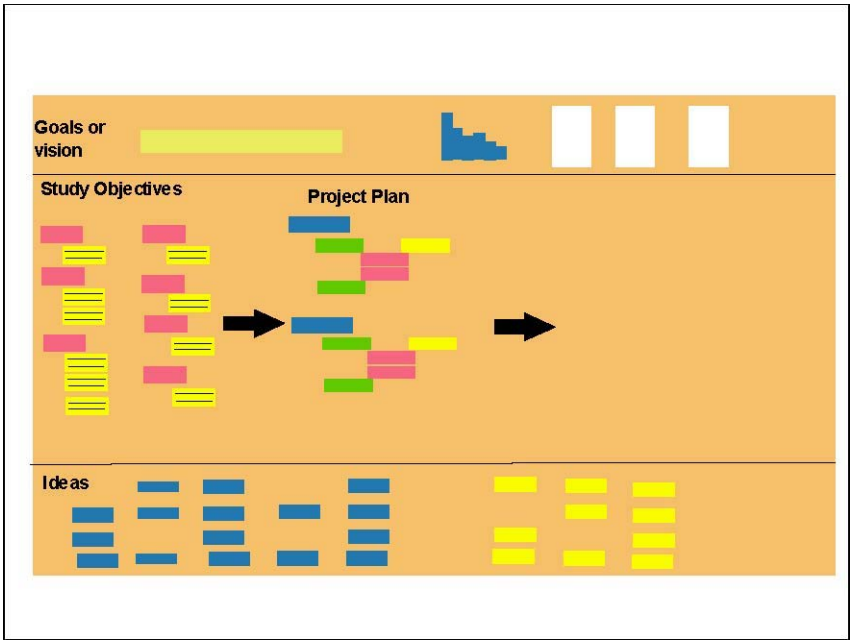

Figure 3-10 Intermediary Steps

The workshop attendees can be working as an entire group, or in smaller working groups throughout the workshop. For example, if wallcharting is used as a tool for process mapping a whole company, then all of the attendees will work together initially (agreeing on standards, conventions, which functional swim lanes will be used, and the overall information flows between sub-processes). Then the workshop will split into a number of small groups to document the process maps (maybe three groups; sales and marketing,

finance, and manufacturing) in a parallel manner. Finally, the entire group will assemble for final checking and validation.

As you can see, the structure for wallcharting is very informal giving no specific guidelines. Each workshop using these techniques is unique, and must be planned accordingly.

Wallcharting produces results that are easy to understand, and if planned correctly, can provide a total picture.

Output

The output from wallcharting is all of the intermediary outputs from each activity, displayed in a logical progression from left to right (all the way around the room if necessary) to the final solution. The following provides some examples of "standard" activities that can be used in wallcharting. Many other activities are possible, limited only by the facilitator's imagination.

Solution Objectives

This activity is generally performed as a first activity in a wallcharting workshop. The attendees will work together and agree on the objectives and scope of the overall workshop objectives, and display them on the brown paper. This activity is useful for the following reasons:

- It enables the attendees to agree on a clear understanding of the objectives.
- It identifies what is in and out of the scope of the workshop.
- It focuses the minds of the attendees. If at a later time, some of the attendees "go off on a tangent," then this agreed on set of objectives can be used to bring them back on-course.
- It mobilizes the attendees to a course of action.

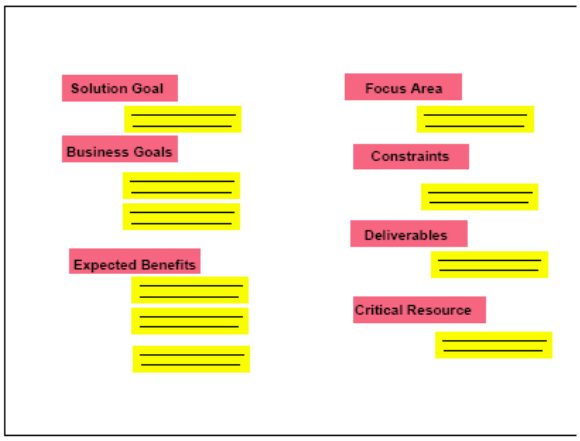

Figure 3-11 Solution Objectives Output Example

Project Plan

A project plan can be produced in a workshop environment through a Wallcharting approach. Achieve this through a combination of brainstorming and group discussions.

The benefit to this approach is that any changes made to the plan (such as changes to attendees at future workshops, or workshops dates being changed) can be updated immediately, and are always available to the workshop attendees.

Figure 3-12 Project Plan Output Example

Task Analysis

Wallcharting is an ideal vehicle for performing task analysis or operational analysis.

The activity shown in the example below describes the activities performed by a sales clerk in the Bookings process. The main part of the chart shows three columns, input information, the process steps performed on the information, and the output from the process (empty in this example).

Red arrows highlight any problem areas (day-end bottleneck and uses a calculator). The pink arrows indicate wished for business objectives (same day processing and trap errors).

A simple graph has been produced, showing work activity between

10.00 and 16.00, and some clipart is used to make the chart more visual (calculator icon).

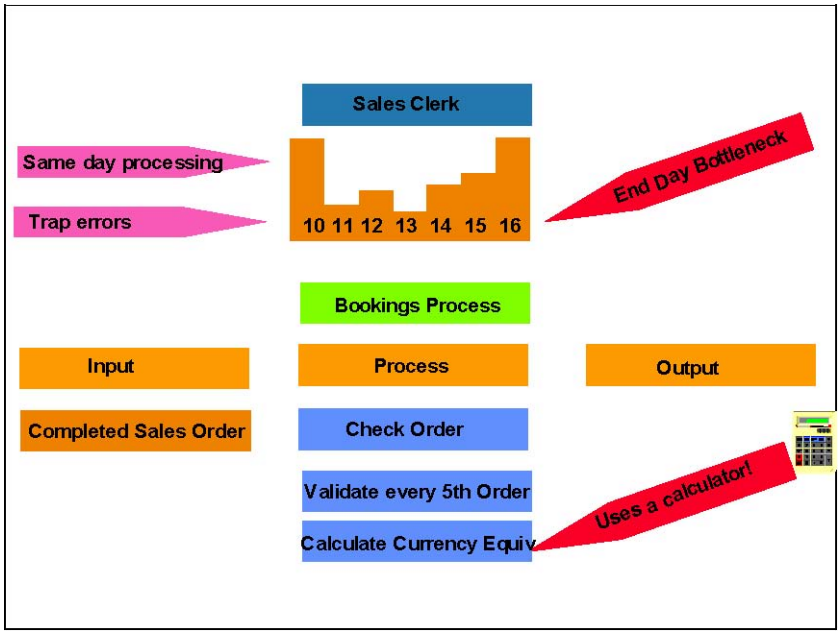

Figure 3-13 Task Analysis Output Example

Information Flow Analysis

A diagonal matrix can be used to document and analyze information flows between sub-processes or departments. This approach has a significant benefit over the traditional flowcharting. It is fully scalable — you can extend the matrix without having to redraw the flowchart.

The matrix is read through a simple convention:

- The large blocks are sub-process steps of functional units. The thinner cards represent information flows.
- Information leaves a block on the horizontal, and it enters the next block where it intersects the vertical. The whole diagram can be read in a clockwise fashion.

In the following example, the information flows:

- **Order (fax)** comes from Customer and goes to Sales Order Processing
- **Del Sched (form)** comes from Manufacturing and goes to Customer

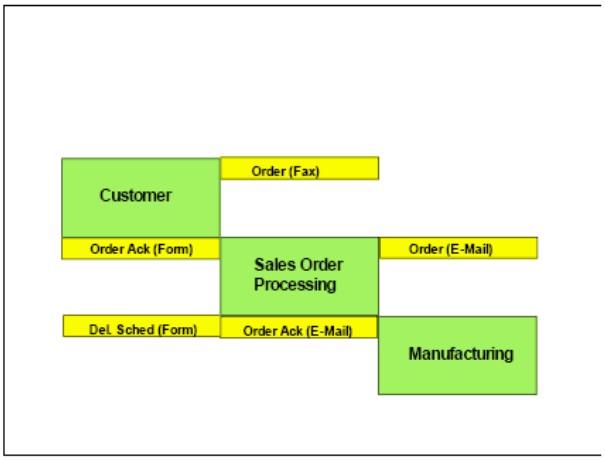

Figure 3-14 Information Flow Analysis Output Example

Process Map

A "swim-lane" description of a process map can easily be described through the wallcharting technique. Different card colors differentiate between manual and automatic steps within a process. Any modification of the process can easily be changed, unlike approaches using white boards or flip charts.

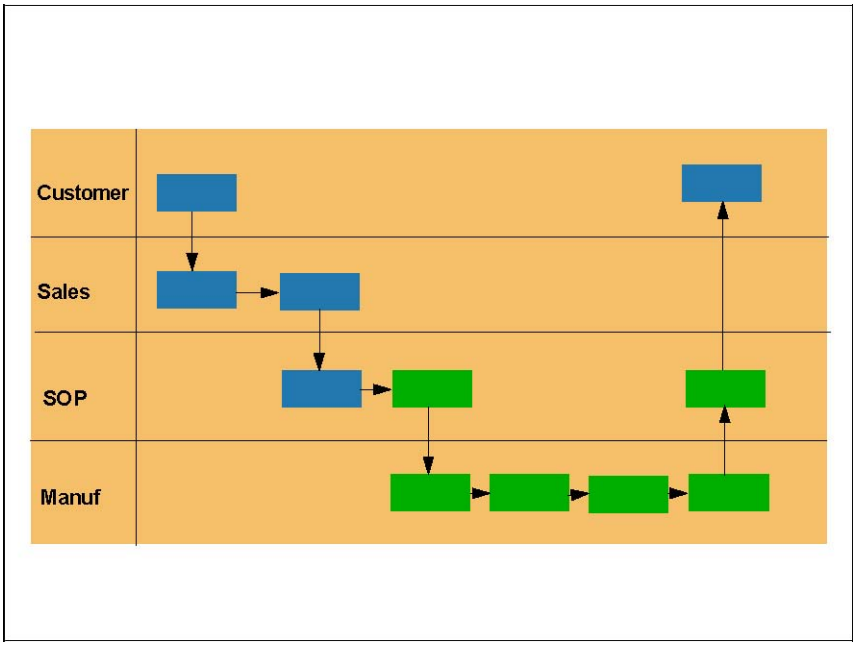

Figure 3-15 Process Map Output Example

Facilitator's Role

The role of the facilitator depends largely on the overall structure of the wallcharting-based workshop, but will always include the following:

- Devise an appropriate card convention.
- Devise the structure of the activities and results.

- Question the attendees to draw out relevant information.
- Question the attendees to test complete understanding and agreement.

Guidelines

The successful completion of a wallcharting session largely depends upon the following factors:

- A dedicated room large enough for the duration of the workshop is required to develop the final solution, and all the intermediate steps.
- One of the drawbacks of wallcharting is documentation. How is the facilitator going to document all output? As a last resort, a photographic record can be used.
- Careful selection of the group is essential. In a very simple wallcharting session, this can easily be achieved. However, if a wallcharting session is planned that will take many months, the coordination of getting the right people in at the right time cannot be underestimated.
- The breakdown of the solution is important. Can one group do it all? If not, how will the groups be coordinated? How many groups will be required to work simultaneously? How will they interface to each other? How can we check the validity of the overall solution?
- Consider the optimum size of a particular work group. If it is too large, nothing gets done; too small, and the group will not have critical mass (sufficient knowledge).

Timings

It is not possible to give specific timings for a wallcharting session, as they range in complexity and scope. Use the following estimates:

Use Wallcharting to Design Screen Layouts:	1 hour
Use Wallcharting to Document all of a customer's existing business processes, and to amend them to support a new suite of applications:	6 months

The facilitator must consider the overall objectives of the project and estimate the activities accordingly.

Hints and Tips

Whenever a wallcharting session is being planned, consider the following:

- Activities, such as task analysis or information flow analysis, require cards other than standard cards (the cards will take up too much space). Cut cards down to a more appropriate size.
- Use actual documents on the wallchart. This provides immediate understanding of information flows.
- Make the intermediate results as visual as possible by:

    - Use pictures or photographs to illustrate appropriately.
    - Define symbols for bottlenecks or information lost.
    - Use Microsoft Word clipart to illustrate issues and problems.
- Remember the following disadvantages:
    - Wallcharting requires a lot of space.
    - It is difficult to keep the output secret.
    - It is difficult to document.
    - Wallcharting is sometimes culturally unacceptable.

SWOT Analysis

Synopsis

SWOT is an acronym for strengths, weaknesses, opportunities, and threats. SWOT is sometimes called WOTS-UP, with the UP simply added to make the term easier to remember.

SWOT analysis is a technique that helps find the best match between environmental trends (opportunities and threats) and internal capabilities (strengths and weaknesses). Although this technique was designed to support strategic business planning decisions, modified approaches are commonly used to differentiate other scenarios (applications, technology, organizations, and objectives).

Rationale

A SWOT analysis helps find the best match between environmental trends (opportunities and threats) and internal capabilities (strengths and weaknesses).

An **opportunity** is any favorable situation in the organization's environment — something that increases demand.

A **threat** is any unfavorable situation in the organization's environment that is potentially damaging to its strategy.

A **strength** is a resource or capacity the organization can use to effectively to achieve its objectives.

A **weakness** is a limitation, fault or defect in the organization that will keep it from achieving its objectives.

A SWOT analysis can help consider internal and external issues in a subjective approach to understanding both sides of any issue, and highlight how its strengths can ward off threats by avoiding them or by correcting or compensating for weaknesses.

Approach

Perform the activity as an entire group, or in individual groups. The approach is the same for both:

1. Identify and agree on the element of an organization we are analyzing:
   - comparative technical architectures
   - culture of the customer compared to it's competitors
   - different approaches to implementing an applications functionality
2. Brainstorm the elements of strengths, weaknesses, opportunities, and threats associated to the element under discussion.

3. Evaluate through discussion, and agree on the strengths, weaknesses, opportunities, and threats associated to the element under discussion.
4. Write them up, usually in matrix format.
5. Agree on actions, based on the matrix.
   - confront - strengths versus threats
   - avoid - weaknesses versus threats
   - exploit - strengths versus opportunities
   - search for - opportunities versus weaknesses
6. Document actions.

Output

The format of a SWOT analysis is in the form of a matrix as follows:

Strengths	Weaknesses
Opportunities	Threats

Figure 3-16 SWOT Analysis Matrix

Facilitator's Role

The role of the facilitator is to:

- Encourage thoughts on their strengths, weaknesses, opportunities and threats.
- Bring experience to the activity. ("Other similar companies do this.… Would you consider this to be a threat?")
- Challenge the groupings. ("Is this really a strength?")

Guidelines

A SWOT analysis only works well if you fully understand what we are analyzing and comparing. The following table gives some examples:

Analysis of:	SWOT Analysis on:
Business Strategy	Internal Competencies vs. External Influences
Technical Architecture	Scenario 1 (Centralized Systems) vs. Scenario 2 (Customer-Server)
Application Functionality	Process Model 1 vs. Process Model 2
Organizations	Organizational Design 1 vs. Organizational Design 2

Table 3-4 SWOT Analysis Examples

If comparing technical architectures, application functionality or organizations, then the strengths and weaknesses are elements that are obviously identified, but the opportunities and threats are not. In these cases, the opportunities are those that will support the overall business needs, and the threats are those that will not support the overall business needs.

Timings

Timings for these types of activity vary considerably. The comparison of two different technical architectures in terms of their ability to support the overall business needs of the organization should be completed in 30 minutes (running each scenario in parallel groups), while a SWOT analysis looking at business strategy may take a whole day.

Hints and Tips

One of the more common problems encountered with a SWOT analysis is that of duplication. For example, when considering a particular technical architecture:

> "A high bandwidth network is an obvious strength."
>
> "And it gives us more opportunities....."
>
> "But the weakness is..... and that makes it a threat to the business goals

This is a symptom of either shallow thinking, or the group's inability to make decisions. The facilitator should thoroughly challenge the group to come to a decision.

Cause (Problem or Consequence) Analysis

Synopsis

Cause analysis is a technique that helps workshop groups identify root-cause problems, which helps the workshop to focus on, rather than identify symptomatic problems and waste time on resolving them.

Each problem has a cause, and each problem has a consequence. In many complex environments, the consequence of one problem is the cause of another. If the cause of one problem is resolved, then both problems disappear. We have eradicated the root-cause problem.

Rationale

During any kind of project, many, many problems already exist and will occur. A cause analysis activity within a workshop can significantly reduce time spent on resolving symptoms.

Approach

Perform this activity as an entire group, or as working groups (although working groups will be required to present back, discuss, and update as necessary). The approach is the same for both:

1. Agree on the area of concentration.
2. Brainstorm (or identify from previous workshop activities) the problems associated with this area.
3. Prioritize the order of impact.
4. Write each problem in the middle column — high impact at the top, low impact at the bottom.
5. Take the first problem, discuss and agree on the cause of this problem, document the causes in the left-hand column.
6. Discuss and agree on the consequences of the problem and document the consequences in the right-hand column.
7. Reiterate the process until all problems have been covered.
8. Analyze the output. Look for consequences being the cause of other problems — identify the root-cause problems.

Output

Typically, a cause analysis is performed in small groups around a flip chart. The output is usually three headed columns on a flip chart (although cards used in a wallcharting session will give the same results).

CAUSE	PROBLEM	CONSEQUENCE

Table 3-5 Typical Cause Analysis Output

Facilitator's Role

The role of the facilitator is simply to challenge the groups to make sure the real causes and consequences of a problem are clearly identified. "Is that really the cause of this problem? How will so-and-so impact this?"

With mixed business function groups, conflict may occur while trying to gain agreement as to the cause of a particular problem. The facilitator must attempt to drive the activity to an agreeable conclusion while defusing any arguments and disagreements.

Guidelines

Everyone can identify a problem, but the causes and consequences usually require discussion with all of the relevant parties. Problems can occur throughout the value chain — root cause problems occur earliest. Make sure that the working group considering a series of problems have representation from all areas within the value chain.

When considering the cause of a problem, it is very easy to make high-level statements, for example, "Manufacturing is always late on delivery." This kind of comment does not add value. The role of the facilitator is to bring out a full understanding of the manufacturing environment and discover the real cause of a problem.

Timings

Although timings may vary depending upon complexity, a good rule-of-thumb is to set aside 10 minutes per problem considered, and 15 minutes analysis time at the end.

Hints and Tips

Perform this kind of activity partway through a workshop, perhaps as part of the baselining phase. Information will have been collected in previous activities. Use this baseline information rather than ask the attendees to reinvent additional problems (unless appropriate).

Force Field Analysis

Synopsis

During any major project, change occurs, and unless addressed, could lead to a loss in performance during the transition. The force field analysis technique enables workshop attendees to consider the impact of change on a project, and begin to agree on the actions necessary to assist the customer's personnel make the transition to the new solution.

Rationale

Change is not necessarily haphazard — it can be planned and controlled. This workshop activity enables the attendees to consider the change management issues relating to a change, and identify ways of dealing with it in a planned and coherent manner.

Approach

The steps necessary for carrying out the force field analysis are:

1. The group should identify the problem on which to work, and define the problem.
2. The problem should now be considered in the following way:
   - Define the current situation.
   - Define the preferred, ideal solution.

   Restate the problem, indicating the direction of the desired change.

1. In most problem situations, there are positive forces (factors) that tend to push towards change for the better — towards improving the situation. There are also conservative forces resisting change and therefore, working to maintain the existence of the problem. Forces for positive change are called **driving forces** and those that inhibit or slow change are **restraining forces**.

   Identify the restraining and driving forces affecting the problem situation previously defined. It is important to be as comprehensive as possible, listing anything that comes to mind, without being too critical.

   Two columns are used on a flip chart to hold the information.
2. The next step is to refine the list gathered in the previous step. One simple method is to underline those forces that are of immediate importance and are able to be influenced in a constructive way.

   The group will identify the one or two driving forces and two or three restraining forces of **key importance.**
3. For each restraining force underlined, list some possible actions that you might be able to plan and implement to reduce its effect or remove it completely.
4. Proceed in the same way for each driving force that has been underlined, listing all actions likely to increase the effect of that force.

5. The list of proposed actions should now be refined, taking into consideration the following issues:
   - Begin the change at the points where strain and stress exist. Further increases in stress may lead to dissatisfaction that can, in turn, lead to increased motivation to change.
   - Attempting to increase driving forces may sometimes result in increasing the opposing restraining forces, in which case it may be that the necessary change could be brought about more easily by reducing the restraining force.

   The actions proposed in steps 5 and 6 should now be reviewed, underlining those actions which seem most likely to succeed.
6. Use the two-column approach, the actions that have been underlined should be listed, identifying for each, the personnel, materials and other resources available for carrying out those actions.
7. Develop an **action plan.**

Output

Typically, the output from this activity is a chart similar to the one shown below:

Actions Proposed	Resources Available

Table 3-6 Workshop Activity Chart

Facilitator's Role

The role of the facilitator is simply to challenge the group so that the real driving forces and restraining forces of a problem are clearly identified.

With mixed business function groups, conflict may occur while trying to gain agreement as to the factors of a particular problem. The facilitator must attempt to drive the activity to an agreeable conclusion while defusing any arguments and disagreements.

Guidelines

Guidelines for selecting the subject follow:

- It must be a subject important to all members of the group.
- It should avoid big abstract issues — concentrate on a specific case.

- It must be something in which the group is personally involved. Ultimately, it must be their problem.
- The group must have some possibility of influencing the situation.

When identifying restraining and driving forces, it is important to consider the following aspects of the business, people and organizational issues:

- personality
- culture
- physical resources and constraints
- emotions
- social and business pressures
- costs
- time restrictions

Timings

Although timings are only approximate, with a clearly defined problem, the whole process should not take more than one hour (but could take significantly longer for complex change management scenarios).

Hints and Tips

This type of activity can get out of hand, by either trying to:

- “boil an ocean,” or
- change things over which the group has no overall control.

The facilitator must attempt to target the activity at realistic problems, and within the influence of the attendees

Nominal Group Technique (NGT)

Synopsis

The nominal group technique is a technique used to resolve issues in a group where the decision needs to be made quickly, but with input from everyone. It consists of the following stages:

- Document the ideas/issues/resolutions and receive preliminary ideas to resolve them.
- Clarify the meaning of items and explain reasons for agreement or disagreement.
- Collect votes on priority of items.
- Move toward a consensus.
- Achieve a final consensus on the issue resolution.
- Review the winning solution for any obvious problems.

Rationale

This workshop technique allows for decisions to be made quickly, but with input from everyone.

Approach

The steps necessary for carrying out the nominal group technique are:

1. Facilitate the silent generation of ideas/issues/resolutions in writing.
    - The Facilitator then presents each issue to the group in written form. (Either pass worksheets out to members of the team, or write the issue on flipchart.)
    - Read the issue and request members to view it carefully.
    - Direct the group to write resolution ideas in brief phases or statements for the next five minutes.
    - Ask the group members to write ideas silently and independently.
    - Follow this process until each issue has been reviewed.
2. Record ideas in round-robin order. For each idea/issue/resolution:
    - Go around the table and ask for one idea from one member at a time.

- Record ideas on a flip chart visible to the entire group.
- Continue recording ideas until all ideas have been written.

3. Facilitate discussion and feedback.
   - Read each idea per issue listed on the flip chart in order and allow a short discussion of each idea.
   - Ask group if there are any questions or statements of clarification, or statements of agreement or disagreement.
4. Conduct preliminary vote.
   - Hand out five 3″x5″ cards to each member.
   - Provide verbal instructions to group:
     - Each member selects the five most important ideas from the flipcharts.
     - Write the identifying words or phrase on each card.
     - On each card, write the item number in the upper left-hand corner of the card.
     - Lay out the cards in front of themselves.
     - Rank the most important and write a ‘5’ in the lower right-hand corner. Turn the card over.
     - Next, rank the least important and write a ‘1’ in the lower right-hand corner. Turn the card over.
     - Continue with the next most important and write a ‘4’ on the card. Turn the card over.
     - Continue with the least important and write a ‘2’ on the card.
     - The remaining card is assigned a ‘3’.
   - Create a ballot sheet on a flip chart, numbering the left-hand side in accordance with the number of items from the round-robin listing.
   - Gather all cards and shuffle them to preserve anonymity.
   - Ask one member to read the item number and the rank number from each card.
   - Tally the rank-order scores on each idea.

5. Discuss preliminary vote.

   Discuss each resolution idea in order of ranking and provide each member a final opportunity to clarify his or her position.

6. Conduct final vote.

   - Hand out five 3″x5″ cards to each member.
   - Provide verbal instructions to group:
     - Write the identifying words or phrase on each card.
     - On each card, write the item number in the upper left-hand corner of the card.
     - Lay out the cards in front of themselves.
     - Rank the most important and write a '5' in the lower right-hand corner. Turn the card over.
     - Next, rank the least important and write a '1' in the lower right-hand corner. Turn the card over.
     - Continue with the next most important and write a '4' on the card. Turn the card over.
     - Continue with the least important and write a '2' on the card.
     - The remaining card is assigned a '3'.
   - Create a ballot sheet on a flip chart, numbering the left-hand side in accordance with the number of items from the round-robin listing.
   - Gather all cards and shuffle them to preserve anonymity.
   - Ask one member to read the item number and the rank number from each card.
   - Tally the final rank-order scores on each idea.

7. Review the winning resolution for any obvious problems.

   Once the meeting has voted and a suggested solution has been provided, then the Facilitator conducts an adverse consequence analysis for any idea that represents a change to the solution standards. The Facilitator should review the suggested resolution and identify if there are obvious and fundamental problems with the solution. It is not intended to be an in depth review. The resolutions are noted and documented in the issue log for publishing

Output

A final resolution to the issue.

Initial Consequence Analysis

Facilitator's Role

The role of the facilitator is to:

- Drive the mechanics of the session.
- Make sure that ideas are generated, grouped and recorded in the given timescale.
- Keep track of time.
- Make sure the activity results in the required output.
- Make sure we maintain the right and appropriate level of detail.
- Keep the group on track.

Guidelines

1. Facilitate the silent generation of ideas in writing.
    - Resist clarifications of the issue and avoid providing ideas to the group.
    - Have the issue in writing on worksheets or flip chart.
    - Model good group behavior by writing in silence.
    - Stop interruptions from individuals who disrupt the silent independent activity.
2. Record ideas in round-robin order.
    - List the entire set of ideas without discussion of any particular idea.
    - Make a clear verbal statement of the step:
    - The objective is to map the group's thinking.
    - Ideas should be brief words or phrases.
    - Duplicate items will be omitted.
    - Variations on themes are desirable.
    - Invite new ideas on subsequent rounds.
    - Record ideas as rapidly as possible.

- Record ideas in the words used by the group member.
- Provide assistance in abbreviating only if necessary.
- Make the entire list of ideas visible to the group by tearing off completed sheets and taping them to the wall.
- Do not discuss or allow argument of ideas as they are presented – indicate to the group that there will be time to discuss ideas in the next step.

Do not debate whether an idea is a duplicate – place responsibility back on the group member who asks.

3. Facilitate discussion and feedback.

    - Verbally define the role of the step as clarification – state that the objective is to clarify ideas, not to win arguments.
    - Help members understand the meaning of the brief words or phrases.
    - Pace the group in order to avoid undue argumentation or neglect of some items at the expense of others.
    - Do not ask individuals to clarify their own items – it is acceptable if they volunteer.

4. Conduct preliminary vote.

    None

5. Discuss preliminary vote.

    - Define the role of the step as clarification, not pressure toward artificial consensus
    - Keep the discussion brief.
    - Caution group members to think carefully about any changes they make in their voting.

6. Conduct final vote.

Timings

The approximate timings for these activities are:

Silent Generation of Ideas:	10 minutes
Record and Share Ideas:	15 – 30 minutes
Discussion and Feedback:	30 - 45 minutes
Discussion and Feedback:	30 - 45 minutes

Hints and Tips

None